
Harmonic Analysis

— *EYNTKA* Series —

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Part I

Harmonic Analysis

(maybe make this a part. There is a problem tho that distribution theory is a more general theory. May move that up to the Function Analysis part and make a chapter on Tempered distributions instead)

Fourier Analysis

In the 19th century, Joseph Fourier was trying to find out how to model the movement of heat through solid bodies, in particular model how heat seems to dissipate and homogenise within its medium. For simplicity, let's say this body was a rod, and we can represent any point on the rod with the interval $[a, b]$. If $u : [0, t] \times [a, b] \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ is a function that at any given point $c \in [a, b]$ and at any given time $t_0 \in [0, t]$ give you the temperature, then Fourier devised that the function u must respect the following differential equation:

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2}$$

which can be interpreted that in any movement in time for some point $c \in [a, b]$, the temperature at c will equal to the *average* of its neighbor (see 3Blue1Brown's video on Fourier analysis for an excellent visualization of this). After choosing the value at $u|_{t_0=0}$ which represent the initial distribution of heat in the rod $[a, b]$, as t_0 changes $u|_{t_0}$ represents the temperature of the rod at every point at time t_0 . Working with this equation, Fourier saw that trigonometric identities are a solution for u given the restraint (with suitable scaling¹). The next insight Fourier had was that a huge amount of functions can be interpreted as an infinite sum of trigonometric functions, and even better, he found how to find the appropriate coefficients for the trigonometric functions! In particular, this family of equations is *dense* in the space of all L^2 functions on a compact interval (or even better, they form an orthonormal basis), and since the PDE in question is *linear*, we can use the Dominated convergence theorem to show that the resulting sequence can mean that $u(0, \cdot)$ can be any L^2 -integrable function (or really, simply integrable since the domain is compact). This is known as the *Fourier Series*, and going from a function to its Fourier series is called the *Fourier Transform*.

This was the beginning of Fourier Analysis, also known as Harmonic Analysis². Since then, it was

¹In particular, some care must be given to the boundary conditions, but this is something that would be covered in more detail in a proper class in PDE's

²Sometimes, Harmonic Analysis is used as a generalization of Fourier Analysis in the case of non-abelian groups, something which will be made more clear in this chapter

asked what spaces of functions admit a Fourier transform, can we go back and forth between the Fourier series and the original function, and can we generalize the domain of the functions (this will be pushed to be compact abelian group, and more generally locally compact groups). The great advantage of being able to find the space of functions that have a Fourier transform is that (under suitable conditions) derivatives work really well with infinite series, trigonometric functions have some of the simple derivatives (they are periodic of order 4), and the Fourier Transform allows us to transfer our problem into a potentially nice space (similarly to how in Representation Theory, it is much easier to find the representation of the monster group to study it rather than directly study it).

These days, Harmonic Analysis has found a large range of applications, from solving my different types of PDE's, to having connections to algebraic number theory (the pursuit of this connection is known as *Langlands Program*). In this chapter, we will cover the elementary theory required to understand the theory of Fourier analysis.

1.1 Basic Definitions for Fourier Analysis

In this chapter, we will always work with $\mathbb{R}^n$ with the Lebesgue measure, denoted m . If $E \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ is measurable, $L^p(E)$ (or $L^p(E, m)$) is the set of all L^p functions from E to $\mathbb{R}$, $C^k(E)$ is the set of all k -times continuously differentiable functions from E to $\mathbb{R}$, $C^\infty(E)$ (the set of all smooth functions from E to $\mathbb{R}$) is equal to $\cap_{k=1}^\infty C^k(E)$, and $C_c^\infty(E)$ is the set of all smooth function whose compact support is in E . If $E = \mathbb{R}^n$, we will often drop the domain of the function space, so:

$$L^p = L(\mathbb{R}^n), \quad C^\infty = C^\infty(\mathbb{R}^n) \quad C_c^\infty = C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^n)$$

The inner product and norm on $\mathbb{R}^n$ is the usual dot product and euclidean norm:

$$x \cdot y = \sum_i^n x_i y_i \quad \|x\| = |x| = \sqrt{x \cdot x}$$

Derivative play a prominent role in this chapter, and so we establish important notation. We will assume the standard basis and write:

$$\partial_j = \frac{\partial}{\partial x^j}$$

and for higher order mixed derivatives, we will use a multi-index, which is an ordered n -tuple $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n)$. As usual:

$$|\alpha| = \sum_1^n \alpha_i \quad \alpha! = \prod_1^n \alpha_i! \quad \partial^\alpha = \left(\frac{\partial}{\partial x_i} \right)^{\alpha_1} \cdots \left(\frac{\partial}{\partial x_n} \right)^{\alpha_n}$$

and for any $x = (x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}^n$:

$$x^\alpha = \prod_1^n x_i^{\alpha_i}$$

Be aware that $|\alpha|$ and $|x|$ do not means the same thing; the meaning should be clear from context. For reference, the product rule on a multi-index expands to:

$$\partial^\alpha (fg) = \sum_{\beta+\gamma=\alpha} \frac{\alpha!}{\beta! \gamma!} (\partial^\beta f) (\partial^\gamma g)$$

A common function we'll use a lot in C_c^∞ is:

$$\psi(x) = \eta(1 - |x|^2) = \begin{cases} \exp((|x|^2 - 1)^{-1}) & |x| < 1 \\ 0 & |x| \geq 1 \end{cases}$$

where $\eta(t) = e^{1/t}\chi_{(0,\infty)}(t)$. Another common subset of C^∞ that will be of use is the following which ensures that a function and all its derivatives decay faster than polynomial time:

Definition 1.1.1: Schwartz Space

The set $\mathcal{S} \subseteq C^\infty$ is the set of all smooth functions and all their derivatives which vanish faster than any power of $|x|$, that is, for any $n \in \mathbb{N}$ and any multi-index α , if we define:

$$\|f\|_{(N,\alpha)} = \sup_{x \in \mathbb{R}^n} (1 + |x|)^n |\partial^\alpha f(x)|$$

Then:

$$\mathcal{S} = \{f \in C^\infty \mid \|f\|_{(N,\alpha)} < \infty \text{ for all } N, \alpha\}$$

Example 1.1.2: Schwartz Functions

1. Naturally, $C_c^\infty \subseteq \mathcal{S}$
2. $f_\alpha(x) = x^\alpha e^{-|x|^2}$ for any multi-index α is in $\mathcal{S}$

Note that if $f \in \mathcal{S}$, then $\alpha f \in L^p$ for all α and all $p \in [1, \infty]$ since $|\partial^\alpha f(x)| \leq C_N(1 + |x|)^{-N}$ for all $N \in \mathbb{N}$, and $(1 + |x|)^{-N} \in L^p$, for all $N > n/p$

Proposition 1.1.3: $\mathcal{S}$ is a Fréchet Space

The Schwartz space $\mathcal{S}$ is a Fréchet space with the topology defined by the norms $\|\cdot\|_{(N,\alpha)}$

Proof:

All is easy to prove with the possible exception of completeness. Let $\{f_k\}$ be a cauchy sequence in $\mathcal{S}$ so that $\|f_i - f_j\|_{(N,\alpha)} \rightarrow 0$ for all N, α . In particular, for each α the sequence $\{\partial^\alpha f_k\}$ converges uniformly to some g_α . Letting e_i denote the standard i th basis vector, we get:

$$f_k(x + te_i) - f_k(x) = \int_0^t \partial_i f_k(x + se_i) ds$$

Letting $k \rightarrow \infty$, we get:

$$g_0(x + te_i) - g_0(x) = \int_0^t g_{e_i}(x + se_i) ds$$

and the fundamental theorem of calculus tells us that $g_{e_i} = \partial_i g_0$, and so by induction we get $g_\alpha = \partial^\alpha g_0$ for all α . From this, it is now easy to verify that $\|f_k - g_0\|_{(N,\alpha)} \rightarrow 0$ for all α and $N \in \mathbb{N}$.

A useful characterization of $\mathcal{S}$ is also the following:

Proposition 1.1.4: Characterizing Schwartz Functions

If $f \in C^\infty$, Then $f \in \mathcal{S}$ if and only if $x^\beta \partial^\alpha f$ is bounded for all multi-indices α, β , if and only if $\partial^\alpha (x^\beta f)$ is bounded for all multi-indices α, β .

Proof:

If $f \in \mathcal{S}$, then naturally $|x^\beta| \leq (1 + |x|)^N$ for $\beta \leq N$. Conversely, notice that $\sum_1^n |x_i|^N$ is strictly positive on the unit sphere $|x| = 1$ (which is compact), and hence has a positive minimum, say δ . It follows that $\sum_1^n |x_i|^N \geq \delta |x|^N$ for all x since both sides are homogeneous of degree N , and hence:

$$(1 + |x|)^N \leq 2^N (1 + |x|^N) \leq 2^N \left[1 + \delta^{-1} \sum_1^n |x_i|^N \right] \leq 2^N \delta^{-1} \sum_{|\beta| \leq N} |x^\beta|$$

Giving the first equivalence. For the second equivalence, notice that for every α , $\partial^\alpha (x^\beta f)$ is a linear combination of terms of the form $x^\gamma \partial^\delta f$ and vice versa, by the product rule, completing the proof.

Next we define a periodic function to be a function for which $f(x + k) = f(x)$ for all $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and $k \in \mathbb{Z}^n$. Without loss of generality the period of the functions will be of size 1. Thus, we can consider the space on which we define periodic functions to be $\mathbb{R}^n / \mathbb{Z}^n \cong (\mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z})^n \equiv \mathbb{T}^n = S^1 \times S^1 \times \cdots \times S^1$, i.e. we can think of defining period functions on an n -torus (note that $\mathbb{T}^1 = S^1$, but $\mathbb{T}^2 \neq S^2$). Naturally, $\mathbb{T}^n$ is a compact Hausdorff space. It can be identified with all points $z = (z_1, z_2, \dots, z_n) \in (\mathbb{C}^n)^*$ with $|z_i| = 1$ via the map

$$(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n) \mapsto (e^{2\pi i x_1}, \dots, e^{2\pi i x_n})$$

For measure-theoretic purposes, we will sometimes identify $\mathbb{T}^n$ with the unit cube:

$$Q = \left[\frac{-1}{2}, \frac{1}{2} \right)^n$$

and when we talk about the Lebesgue measure on $\mathbb{T}^n$, we will mean the induced measure from Q . This means that $m(\mathbb{T}^n) = 1$. We will think of functions on $\mathbb{T}^n$ as either periodic functions on $\mathbb{R}^n$ or as functions on Q (the context will make it clear which we pick).

Exercise 1.1.1

1. Is the sum of two periodic functions periodic?

1.1.1 Convolution

In this section, we introduce a new way of multiplying two functions that will be very useful and very natural. The naturality comes from the discrete case, and so we will start with it: recall that if we have two polynomials $p(x)$ and $q(x)$ (which can be thought of as formal sums, bringing in the

naturality), then the multiplication formula which groups the terms of the same degree is:

$$\left(\sum_{i=0}^{\deg(p)} p_i x^i \right) \cdot \left(\sum_{j=0}^{\deg(q)} q_j x^j \right) = \sum_{k=0}^{\deg(p)+\deg(q)} \left(\sum_{i+j=k} p_i q_j \right) x^k = \sum_{k=0}^{\deg(p)+\deg(q)} \left(\sum_{l=0}^k p_l q_{k-l} \right) x^k$$

If we set p_k or q_{l-k} to zero if k or $l - k$ is negative, then we can re-write the sum as:

$$\left(\sum_{i=0}^{\deg(p)} p_i x^i \right) \cdot \left(\sum_{j=0}^{\deg(q)} q_j x^j \right) = \sum_{k=0}^{\deg(p)+\deg(q)} \left(\sum_{-\infty}^{\infty} p_l q_{k-l} \right) x^k$$

If we let $p[n]$ and $q[n]$ represent the coefficient of the n th degree term, and $h = pq$, then:

$$h[n] = \sum_{k=-\infty}^{\infty} p_k q_{n-k}$$

We can write this as:

$$h[n] = [p * q][n] = \sum_{k=-\infty}^{\infty} p_k q_{n-k}$$

where $p * q$ is a compact notation the right hand side. The summation can be thought of as representing the discrete measure. Generalized to the continuous case, this is called *convolution*:

Definition 1.1.5: Convolution

Let f, g be measurable on $\mathbb{R}^n$. Then the *convolution* of f and g is a function $f * g : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ defined by:

$$f * g(x) := \int f(x - y)g(y)dy$$

for all x such that the integral exists

To see this in action, Let $f = \chi_{[0,1]}$ and $g = \chi_{[0,1]}$, and you'll find that $f * g$ is a triangle. You can imagine sliding the graph of f and finding the area of the intersection of f and g , and plotting it. There are many ways to make sure that $f * g$ is a.e. defined. For example, if f was bounded and compactly supported, g can be locally integrable. Note that in many cases, we will need that $K(x, y) = f(x - y)$ be measurable on $\mathbb{R}^n \times \mathbb{R}^n$. If we let $s(x, y) = x - y$, then since s is continuous, if f is Borel measurable, so is K . (Folland makes a comment here saying we can "assume" that this is the case, which I'm guessing is f being Borel measurable in the definition of convolution, because of his theorem 2.12, which is my proposition ??, and he says the same can happen for Lebesgue measurability). Usually, we will use convolution to somehow combine the property of two functions f and g . We will soon see that convolution often preserves the "nice" properties the "nicer" function, so that we would convolution, say, a smooth function f with an integrable function g to get a smooth function $f * g$.

I would also be remiss if I don't mention that convolution is like multiplying two functions in a way that respects operation the *domain*. If f, g are real functions, then $f \cdot g$ respects the multiplication in the *codomain* as it multiplies the outputs. As $f * g$ is the continuous case of polynomial multiplication which multiplies, it respects the multiplication happening in the *domain*. To motivate why this is

worth pointing out, consider a finite group G , $f \in \text{Hom}_{\text{Set}}(G, \mathbb{R})$, and interpret it as an element of $\mathbb{C}[G]$ so that $f = \sum_i a_i g_i$. Then we can always make $r \in \mathbb{R}$ act on f via:

$$r \cdot f(g_i) = rf(g_i)$$

However, we can also make $g \in G$ act on f :

$$g \cdot f(g_i) = f(g^{-1}g_i)$$

where we inverse for associativity:

$$\begin{aligned} (g \cdot (h \cdot f))(x) &= (h \cdot f)(g^{-1}x) \\ &= f(h^{-1}(g^{-1}x)) \\ &= f((h^{-1}g^{-1})x) \\ &= f((gh)^{-1}x) \\ &= ((gh) \cdot f)(x) \end{aligned}$$

This is the same thing as defining $g \cdot f$ given $f \in \mathbb{C}[G]$ since:

$$gf = g \cdot \sum_{g_i \in G} a_i g_i = \sum_{g_i \in G} a_i (gg_i) = \sum_{g^{-1}g_i \in G} a_i g_i$$

Thus, we may think of the translation operation as an action from the structure of the *domain*, when the domain has a group structure. It shall turn out that the way of characterizing the orthonormal basis for L^2 that gives rise to the Fourier transform is to choose the one that's invariant under τ_y .

Definition 1.1.6: Translation Operator

If $f : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$, then

$$y * f(x) = \tau_y f(x) = f(x - y)$$

Notice that:

$$\|\tau_y f\|_p = \|f\|_p \quad \|\tau_y f\|_u = \|f\|_u$$

Using this, we can give another definition of uniformly continuous: f is uniformly continuous if:

$$\|\tau_y f - f\|_u \rightarrow 0$$

Lemma 1.1.7: Compact Support Functions And UC

If $f \in C_c(\mathbb{R}^n)$, then f is uniformly continuous

Proof:

should be easy proof (Folland p.238)

Proposition 1.1.8: Translation Is Continuous In L^p

If $1 \leq p < \infty$, then translation is continuous in the L^p norm, in particular if $f \in L^p$ and $z \in \mathbb{R}^n$, then

$$\lim_{y \rightarrow 0} \|\tau_{y+z} f - \tau_z f\|_p = 0$$

Note this proposition is false when $p = \infty$

Proof:

Folland p. 238

The following results all work over $\mathbb{R}^n$ or $\mathbb{T}^n$ (interpreted as the unit cube)

Proposition 1.1.9: Algebraic Properties Of Convolution

Assume all the following integrals are defined and converge absolutely. Then:

1. $f * g = g * f$
2. $(f * g) * h = f * (g * h)$ (this result in particular requires absolute convergence)
3. $f * (g + h) = f * g + f * h$
4. $a(f * g) = (af) * g$ for all $a \in \mathbb{C}$
5. for all $z \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $\tau_z(f * g) = (\tau_z f) * g = f * (\tau_z g)$
6. If A is the closure of $\{x + y \mid x \in \text{supp}(f), y \in \text{supp}(g)\}$, then $\text{supp}(f * g) \subseteq A$

Proof:

1.

$$\begin{aligned}
 f * g(x) &= \int f(x - y)g(y)dy \\
 &= \int f(z)g(x - z)dz && z = x - y, y = x - z \\
 &= \int g(x - z)f(z)dz \\
 &= g * f(x)
 \end{aligned}$$

2. Follows from (1) from Fubini's theorem
3. Follows from direct computation
4. Follows from direct computation
5. Follows from direct computation and (1)
6. If $x \notin A$, then for any $y \in \text{supp}(g)$, we have $x - y \notin \text{supp}(f)$, thus $f(x - y)g(y) = 0$, i.e. $f * g(x) = 0$

One of the first properties important to establish is the relation between convolution of a function and p -norms:

Theorem 1.1.10: Young's Inequality

Let $1 \leq p, q, r \leq \infty$ be such that $p^{-1} + q^{-1} = r^{-1} + 1$, and let $f \in L^p$ and $g \in L^q$. Then $f * g(x)$ exists for a.e. x , $f * g \in L^r$ and

$$\|f * g\|_r \leq \|f\|_p \|g\|_q$$

Notice in the statement that we have something a little different than the usual conjugate exponents. To see why, there is another thing worth pointing out, which is that this condition is stable under scaling. In particular, if $f_\lambda(x) = f(\lambda x)$ and $g_\lambda(x) = g(\lambda x)$. Then:

$$\begin{aligned} \|f_\lambda\|_p &= \left(\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(\lambda x)^p \right)^{1/p} \\ &= \left(\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} \lambda^{-n} f(y)^p \right)^{1/p} & y = \lambda x, \quad dy = \lambda^n dx \\ &= \lambda^{-n/p} \|f\|_p \end{aligned}$$

where λ^n is the determinant of the Jacobian matrix. So:

$$\begin{aligned} (f_\lambda * g_\lambda)(x) &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(\lambda x - \lambda y) g(\lambda y) dy \\ &= \lambda^{-n} (f * g)(\lambda x) \end{aligned}$$

Thus we have:

$$\begin{aligned} \|f_\lambda * g_\lambda\|_r &= \lambda^{-n} \|(f * g)_\lambda\|_r \\ &= \lambda^{-n/r-n} \|f * g\|_r \\ &\leq \lambda^{-n/p-n/q} \|f\|_p \|g\|_q \end{aligned}$$

Notice that this inequality must hold for *all* $\lambda > 0$. If the exponents of λ on the left and right sides were different, we could force a contradiction by taking $\lambda \rightarrow 0$ or $\lambda \rightarrow \infty$ (one side would vanish while the other explodes). Thus, the exponents must be equal:

$$-n \left(1 + \frac{1}{r} \right) = -n \left(\frac{1}{p} + \frac{1}{q} \right)$$

Dividing out the $-n$, we recover the necessary condition:

$$1 + \frac{1}{r} = \frac{1}{p} + \frac{1}{q}$$

Intuitively, the “extra” $+1$ comes from the integration dy in the definition of convolution, which adds n dimensions of volume (unlike pointwise multiplication which preserves the exponent balance of Hölder's inequality).

Proof:

First, consider $r = \infty$, meaning $r^{-1} = 0$, $p^{-1} + q^{-1} = 1$. So, we want to show $\|f * g\|_\infty \leq \|f\|_p \|g\|_q$. So:

$$\begin{aligned} \|f * g\|_\infty &= \sup_x \left| \int f(x-y)g(y)dy \right| \\ &\leq \|f(x-\cdot)\|_p \|g\|_q \\ &\stackrel{!}{=} \|f\|_p \|g\|_q \end{aligned}$$

where $\stackrel{!}{=}$ comes from $\int |h(x-y)|dy = \int |h(y)|dy$ where $z = x-y$, $dz = (-1)^n dy$ so the $(-1)^n$ disappears in the absolute value. (Note: I corrected the L^1 typo to L^∞ here to match the case $r = \infty$).

Next, if p or q is 1 (say $p = 1$), then $1 + q^{-1} = r^{-1} + 1$, so $q^{-1} = r^{-1}$. Then we would have:

$$\|f * g\|_q \leq \|f\|_1 \|g\|_q$$

To see that this happens, we use theorem ???. In particular, let $K(x, y) = f(x-y)$. Then if $\|g\|_q$ exists, $\|K(x, \cdot)\|_1 = \|f\|_1$ and $\|K(\cdot, y)\| = \|f\|_1$, giving us the result.

Now, assume $1 < p < r$, $1 < q < r$. First, we manipulate it to be able to use Hölder's inequality:

$$|f(y)g(x-y)| = (|f(y)|^p |g(x-y)|^q)^{1/r} |f(y)|^{1-p/r} |g(x-y)|^{1-q/r}$$

Next, notice that:

$$\frac{1}{r} + \frac{r-q}{rq} + \frac{r-p}{rp} = \frac{1}{r} \left(1 + \frac{r}{q} - 1 + \frac{r}{p} - 1 \right) = 1$$

So, we can apply general Hölder's inequality since $r-p, r-q \neq 0$ which gives us:

$$\begin{aligned} |(f * g)(x)| &\leq \left(\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} |f(y)|^p |g(x-y)|^q dy \right)^{1/r} \cdot \|f\|_p^{(r-p)/r} \|g\|_q^{(r-q)/r} \\ \Rightarrow |(f * g)(x)|^r &\leq \left(\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} |f(y)|^p |g(x-y)|^q dy \right) \cdot \|f\|_p^{r-p} \|g\|_q^{r-q} \end{aligned}$$

And now, we can integrate the left hand side with respect to x and use Tonelli's theorem:

$$\Rightarrow \|(f * g)\|_r^r \leq \|f\|_p^p \|f\|_p^{r-p} \|g\|_q^q \|g\|_q^{r-q} = \|f\|_p^r \|g\|_q^r$$

completing the proof.

If we focus on the special case of $p = q = r = 1$, then $f * g \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$. Then proposition 1.1.9 and Young's inequality (theorem 1.1.10) turns $L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ into a "commutative associative algebra". Note that this algebra has no multiplicative identity (i.e. We are working over a *rng*). It does have a notion of an identity in a limit, which we will shortly explore. In fact, if we slightly correctly loosen our notion of function to *distribution*, we shall naturally recover an identity (explored in chapter 2). Note that if $f, g \in L^2(\mathbb{R}^n)$ then $f * g \in L^\infty(\mathbb{R}^n)$, namely convoluting forces the functions the result to be bounded.

Before exploring a notion of identity, it must be shown that convoluting two functions where one

nicer than the other usually keeps the properties of the nicer function:

Lemma 1.1.11: Convolution Preserves C_c^k

Let $f \in L^1$ and $g \in C_c^k$ (more generally, $\partial^\alpha g$ is bounded for $|\alpha| \leq k$). Then

$$f * g \in C^k$$

and

$$\partial^\alpha (f * g) = (f * \partial^\alpha g)$$

Proof:

In Folland textbook, he says it's clear from theorem ??.

This is a matter of computation. We'll do the case of $k = 1$, since the rest is a matter of induction. First, write what you know about $f * g$:

$$\begin{aligned} f * g(x) &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x-y)g(y)dy \\ &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(y)g(x-y)dy \end{aligned}$$

So consider

$$\lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{f * g(x+h) - f * g(x)}{h} = \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(y) \left(\frac{g(x+h-y) - g(x-y)}{h} \right) dy$$

Notice that:

$$\left| \frac{g(x+h-y) - g(x-y)}{h} \right| \leq \frac{|g'(c)| \cdot h}{h}$$

meaning we have a dominating function, and so we can apply dominated convergence theorem to move the limit in!

$$\begin{aligned} \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \frac{f * g(x+h) - f * g(x)}{h} &= \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(y) \left(\frac{g(x+h-y) - g(x-y)}{h} \right) dy \\ &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(y) \lim_{h \rightarrow 0} \left(\frac{g(x+h-y) - g(x-y)}{h} \right) dy \end{aligned}$$

and since $g \in C_c^1$ (in particular, g is differentiable), this limit exists, and since g has compact support, the integral is still well-defined and is C^1 (see the remarks we made at the beginning).

From here we can apply the induction, and the proof is done.

Proposition 1.1.12: Smooth Function Dense in L^p

Compact smooth functions (and hence Schwartz functions) are dense in L^p .

Proof:

hint: simple functions are dense in L^p . Convolute them with a smooth bump function.

Proposition 1.1.13: Convolution in Schwartz Space

Let $f, g \in \mathcal{S}$. Then $f * g \in \mathcal{S}$

Proof:

First, $f * g \in C^\infty$ by lemma 1.1.11. Next, we establish the following for the coming chain of inequalities:

$$1 + |x| \stackrel{\Delta_{\text{ineq.}}}{\leq} 1 + |x - y| + |y| \leq (1 + |x - y|)(1 + |y|)$$

and so:

$$\begin{aligned} (1 + |x|)^N |\partial^\alpha (f * g)(x)| &\leq \int (1 + |x - y|)^N |\partial^\alpha f(x - y)| (1 + |y|)^N |g(y)| dy \\ &= \|f\|_{(N, \alpha)} \|g\|_{(N+n+1, \alpha)} \int (1 + |y|)^{-n-1} dy \end{aligned}$$

which is certainly finite

With this information, we are going to define a notion of “multiplicative identity”

Definition 1.1.14: Good Kernels

Let $\{\varphi_t\}_{t>0}$ be a set of functions of the form $\varphi_t : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$. Then they are called a *good kernel* if $t \in (0, \epsilon_0)$ and:

1. $\sup_{t>0} \|\varphi_t\|_1 < \infty$
2. $\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} \varphi_t(x) dx = 1$
3. $\lim_{t \rightarrow 0} \int_{|x|>\delta} |\varphi_t(x)| dx = 0$ for all $\delta > 0$

Theorem 1.1.15: Good Kernels Like Mult. Identity

Let $f \in L^p$ for $1 \leq p < \infty$ (note it is $<$, not $\leq$), then:

$$f * \varphi_t \rightarrow f$$

in L^p as $t \rightarrow \infty$. Furthermore, if f is continuous at some x_0 , then:

$$f * \varphi_t(x_0) \rightarrow f(x_0)$$

in L^p

Proof:

It is equivalent to show $f * \varphi_t - f \rightarrow 0$, so for all x :

$$\begin{aligned}
 f * \varphi_t(x) - f(x) &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x-y)\varphi_t(y)dy - f(x) \cdot 1 \\
 &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x-y)\varphi_t(y)dy - f(x) \cdot \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} \varphi_t(y)dy \\
 &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x-y)\varphi_t(y)dy - \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x)\varphi_t(y)dy \\
 &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} [f(x-y) - f(x)]\varphi_t(y)dy \\
 &= \int_{|y| \leq \delta} [f(x-y) - f(x)]\varphi_t(y)dy + \int_{|y| > \delta} [f(x-y) - f(x)]\varphi_t(y)dy
 \end{aligned}$$

and so, taking the p -norm we get:

$$\|f * \varphi_t - f\|_p \leq \int_{|y| \leq \delta} \|f(\cdot - y) - f(\cdot)\|_p |\varphi_t(y)| dy + \int_{|y| > \delta} 2\|f\|_p |\varphi_t(y)| dy$$

at this point, we are almost done. If we let $c = \sup_{t>0} \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} |\varphi_t(y)| dy$, then we get:

$$\limsup_{t \rightarrow 0} \|f * \varphi_t - f\|_p \leq c \limsup_{\delta \rightarrow 0, |y| \leq \delta} \|f(\cdot - y) - f(\cdot)\|_p = 0$$

where the last inequality comes from the shrinking delta.

It was left as an exercise to do the point-convergence in the continuous case.

Note that if f is uniformly continuous and bounded, then $f * \varphi_t \rightarrow f$ uniformly, and if $\int \varphi = a$, then $f * \varphi_t \rightarrow af$.

Example 1.1.16: Good Kernels

Let $X(x) \in C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^n)$ where $\int X = 1$. Then:

$$\varphi_t(x) = t^{-n} X(x/t)$$

is a good kernel (ex. let $X(x) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{\pi}} e^{-x^2}$). This is just a matter of computation. Note that $\varphi_t = 0$ if $\frac{x}{t} \geq c_0$ for some c_0 , and so $t \leq \frac{x}{c_0}$. It [somehow] follows that C_c^∞ is *dense* in L^p ($1 \leq p < \infty$) (note the $<$ and not $\leq$)

For another Another example of a family of good kernel, take:

$$K_\delta(x) = \delta^{-1/2} e^{-\frac{\pi x^2}{\delta}}$$

These can be visualized here:

<https://www.desmos.com/calculator/e8xc37r3ck>

Notice that since the function $X \in C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R})$ is smooth on compact support then by lemma 1.1.11, $f * X$ is also smooth, and will remain smooth for every φ_n . Since $f * \varphi_n \rightarrow f$, we see that a sequence of smooth functions converges to an L^p function, meaning smooth functions are *dense* in L^p !

I found this interesting stack-exchange post on the importance of good Kernels:

<https://math.stackexchange.com/questions/3294744/good-kernels-that-exist-in-the-real-world>

Using the fact that convolution preserves the “nicer” structure, we strengthen’s Urysohn’s lemma (or, if you know some differential geometry, generalizes partitions of unity)

Theorem 1.1.17: Smooth Urysohn’s Lemma

Let $K \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ be compact and $U \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ be open and contain K ($U \supseteq K$). Then there exists a $f \in C_c^\infty$ such that $0 \leq f \leq 1$ and $f \equiv 1$, K and $\text{supp}(K) \subseteq f$.

Proof:

Since K is compact, then $\delta = \rho(K, U^c)$ (the shortest distance from K and U^c) is non-zero. We are going to do a similar trick to that of lemma ???: let $V = \{x \mid \rho(x, K) < \frac{\delta}{3}\}$. Choose some $\varphi \in C_c^\infty$ such that $\int \varphi = 1$ and $\varphi(x) = 0$ for $|x| \geq \delta/3$ (as an example, $\{\psi_t\}$ to be a good kernel and take $\varphi = (\int \psi)^{-1} \psi_{\delta/3}$).

Now, let $f = \chi_V * \varphi$. Then as we’ve shown before, $f \in C_c^\infty$, and it is easy to see that $0 \leq f \leq 1$, $f \equiv 1$ on K , and $\text{supp}(f) \subseteq \{x \mid \rho(x, K) \leq 2\delta/3\} \subseteq U$

1.2 Fourier Transform

Consider again the heat equation on a compact interval:

$$\frac{du}{dt} = \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} \quad (1.1)$$

where u is a solution. If u represents a rod that is at time $t = 0$ half hot and half cold and is touching in the middle, then we let time move forward, the temperature will dampen out due to the 2nd term. The shape goes from a bump function, to a function that looks like $\tan^{-1}(x)$, and as time $\rightarrow \infty$ it converges to a constant function representing the average temperature. These are all functions with distinctly different behaviours.

Now, assume that the heat of the rod at $t = 0$ has the shape of $\sin(x)$ or $\cos(x)$. Then as we let time propagate these functions dampen uniformly, notably *they are always the same function*, simply scaled. This is essentially the behaviour of *eigenvectors*, namely as time moves forward we are scaling by a factor. To have eigenvectors, we need a linear transformation between vector spaces. Let S_t be the *time evolution operator* that takes in a state f_{t_0} (a function on the domain that is a t_0 -slice of a solution $u(x, t_0)$) and outputs f_{t_0+t} , in particular $S_t : \mathcal{P}(X) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}(X)$ where $\mathcal{P}(X)$ is the state space over X and S_t is the evolve by t operator:

$$S_t(u(-, t_0)) = u(-, t_0 + t)$$

Or, viewed as an (abelian) monoid action³:

$$S : [0, \infty) \times \mathcal{P}(X) \rightarrow \mathcal{P}(X) \quad t \cdot f_{t_0} = f_{t_0+t}$$

Note that it isn't "obvious" what type of space $\mathcal{P}(X)$ is, we will harmlessly assume that this is the Hilbert spaces; see [NatePDE] for the justification of this assumption. At minimum it is certainly the case that any (smooth) L^2 -integrable function is a valid starting state that can then evolve according to the heat equation. If the reader can accept that there is a reasonable sense in which integrable function can be differentiated as shall be demonstrated in chapter 2, the reader can let $\mathcal{P}(X) = L^2([0, 1])$.

Now, certainly S_t is linear as the heat equation is linear and homogeneous⁴. We can thus ask if it has eigenvectors, that is function $f_r \in \mathcal{P}(X)$ where

$$S_t f_r(x) = \lambda_t f_r(x)$$

If we let t vary, we can define a function $\lambda(t)$ dependent on the time. Given a compact domain $X = [a, b]$, by direct computations we can check that $\sin(kx)$ is an eigenvector, where this is indeed a state as it is a t -slice of:

$$u(x, t) = e^{-k^2 t} \sin(kx)$$

For example at $t = 0$:

$$S_t(\sin(kx)) = e^{-k^2 t} \sin(kx)$$

With the assumption that $\mathcal{P}$ is a Hilbert space, if these eigenfunctions form an orthonormal basis, we can decompose a functions into a "weighted sum" of these well-behaved functions with respect to time. For the rest of this section we shall take for granted $\{\sin(kx)\}_{k \in \mathbb{N}}$ form orthonormal basis for S_t (proven in theorem 1.2.4) after appropriately normalized depending on the domain.

It must be pointed out that the same argument works for $\cos(kx)$:

$$S_t(\cos(kx)) = e^{-k^2 t} \cos(kx)$$

and these *also* form an orthonormal basis that *also* diagonalize S_t . These two sets certainly cannot be combined since the result is no longer orthogonal:

$$\int_0^1 \sin(\pi x) \cos(2\pi x) dx = \frac{-2}{3\pi} \neq 0$$

Thus, the question shifts into one about finding a *natural* eigenbasis for S_t . A-priori, it is not necessarily the case that these are the only eigenbasis. What we need is for the eigenbasis to "respect" some inherent geometry of the space. Phrased differently, the eigenbasis needs to be *invariant* with respect to some operator(s), where the operators represent some symmetry of the space. To get a better grasp of invariance of operators, we may start looking at other PDEs and considering diagonalizing the operator S_t with respect to the solutions of those PDEs.

For example, if we solve the Heat equation on a sphere:

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial t} = \Delta_{\text{sphere}} u$$

³The heat equation is not well-defined on the full real line $\mathbb{R}$, it fails the Hadamards conditions for well-posedness; see [NatePDE]

⁴It is also continuous and normal, but for that we would need to choose whether we consider $\mathcal{P}$ as a Banach space or a distribution space; intuitively the heat equation dissipates energy so $\|S_t f\| \leq \|f\|$

the operator can still be diagonalized (see [NatePDE]). What we shall want is for an eigenbasis that respects the spherical geometry, namely for it to be invariant to an $SO(3)$ action. Such eigenfunctions do exist, they are the *Spherical Harmonics* $Y_l^m(\theta, \varphi)$, and they are invariant to rotation⁵

$$\Delta(f \circ R) = (\Delta f) \circ R$$

To give another example that is famous in physics, consider Quantum Harmonic Oscillator

$$i \frac{\partial \psi}{\partial t} = -\frac{\partial^2 \psi}{\partial x^2} + x^2 \psi$$

This PDE is diagonalizable (see [NatePDE]), but it is *not* diagonalizable by $e^{2\pi i k}$. Instead it was shown to be diagonalized (uniquely) by the *Hermite Functions* (a Gaussian multiplied by a polynomial)

$$\varphi_n(x) = H_n(x) e^{-x^2/2}$$

By trying to diagonalize with $e^{2\pi i k}$, the x^2 multiplication term turns into a Laplacian in k -space ($-\partial_k^2$), so the result will effectively just swap the PDE for an identical PDE in frequency space without solving it. In physics, this fact shall be the key to showing that it is in fact *invariant* to the Fourier transform, creating fascinating link between abstract harmonic analysis and the concrete geometry of quantum mechanics, a connection to be explored in another book.

So what is the invariance we want to impose for the operator S_t with respect to the heat equation? In the example of the sphere, we had that the group $SO(3)$. A compact interval has no inherent invariance simply because it is not a group. However, by gluing the end points of the interval we get a 1-torus (a circle)⁶. We now have the rotation group operation on $\mathbb{T}^1$, or equivalently the translation operation on $\mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$ ⁷. This does shift the geometry and hence the inherent dynamics of our PDEs; the problem of solving a PDE on a compact interval will be a subset of solving PDEs on a torus as shall be addressed shortly. Let us first simply consider S_t on $L^2(\mathbb{T}^1)$ and see how it interacts with the translation operator. Since we are working on the torus, we now have that $\sin(2\pi kx)$ and $\cos(2\pi lx)$ are orthogonal (where the 2π -scaling was to ensure a full period of each lies within the torus), and $\{\sin(kx), \cos(lx)\}_{k,l \in \mathbb{N}}$ is an orthonormal basis (after appropriate scaling and stretching). Now, note that sin and cos basis are *not* translation invariant, for example:

$$\tau_a(\sin(kx)) = \sin(k(x+a)) = \sin(kx) \cos(ka) + \cos(kx) \sin(ka)$$

and so they are not eigenvectors of τ_a . However, they still *block-diagonalize* the translation operator τ_a with blocks of size 2:

$$\begin{pmatrix} \cos(ka) & \sin(ka) \\ -\sin(ka) & \cos(ka) \end{pmatrix}$$

If we look at these blocks, we shall see that they are all rotation matrices by an angle ka ; in other words the imposition is that we did not have enough eigenvalues. By extending the codomain to $\mathbb{C}$, we can readily verify that:

$$\tau_a(e^{iz}) = e^{ia} \cdot e^{iz}$$

⁵important technicality: $SO(3)$ is not abelian, hence it cannot be that *all* rotation operators simultaneously commute. The best solution is to pick a “maximal set” of commuting symmetries: usually the Total Angular Momentum (L^2 , representing the amount of rotation invariance) and Azimuthal Symmetry (L_z , rotation around the z-axis).

⁶More generally, any rectangular domain is homeomorphic to $[0, 1]^n$ which then can be glued to become $\mathbb{T}^n = (S^1)^n$, and so this same translation structure appears in higher dimensions

⁷Really $\mathbb{C}/\mathbb{Z}$ as we shall justify shortly

and so $\{e^{ikz}\}_{k \in \mathbb{Z}}$ is our desired eigenbasis for τ_a . Now, the question remains these translations of these functions commute with S_t , namely:

$$S_t(\tau_a(f)) = \tau_a(S_t(f)) \quad \forall a \in \mathbb{T}^1$$

and indeed:

$$\begin{aligned} \tau_a(S_t(e^{ikx})) &= \tau_a(e^{-k^2 t} e^{ikx}) \\ &= e^{-k^2 t} e^{ik(x+a)} \\ &= e^{-k^2 t} e^{ika} e^{ikx} \\ &= e^{ika} S_t(e^{ikx}) \\ &= S_t(e^{ika} e^{ikx}) && S_t \text{ is linear} \\ &= S_t(\tau_a(e^{ikx})) \end{aligned}$$

What this means physically is that the heat equation dissipates the same way no matter where you are on a ring-shaped rod. If the rod was half wood and half metal, then this translation invariance shall fail.

Now, notice that as $\tau_a \circ S_t = S_t \circ \tau_a$ for all $a \in \mathbb{T}^1$ (or in commutator bracket notation $[\tau_a, S_t] = 0$ for all a, t), the eigenvectors of τ_a are the same eigenvectors as S_t . The eigenvectors of S_t are in general hard to compute, but the eigenvectors of τ_a are *precisely* the functions e^{ikx} . In fact, Any (linear) operator L where $\tau_a \circ L = L \circ \tau_a$ will have the same eigenvectors. Thus, we are actually finding eigenvectors of the translation operators τ_a and then finding transformation that commute with translation. Note that any Linear Differential Operator with Constant Coefficients

$$L = a_n \frac{d^n}{dx^n} + \cdots + a_1 \frac{d}{dx} + a_0$$

and any convolution operator:

$$L(f) = f * g = \int f(y)g(x-y)dy$$

will commute with translation. This is also why the Heat Equation, Wave Equation, and Schrödinger Equation can all be solved (or transformed) using the Fourier transform.

Boundary Problem

The immediate point that is still pending and must be clarified when switching to $\mathbb{T}^1$ is that this shifts the dynamics of any PDE we are solving, as now points at the boundary are affected by their neighbourhood. However, for PDE's that will respect the group structure of $\mathbb{T}^1$, the effects at the boundary can be “cancelled out” in two separate ways that shall recover the original two basis $\{\sin(kx)\}_{k \in \mathbb{Z}}$ and $\{\cos(kx)\}_{k \in \mathbb{Z}}$ we saw before (again, appropriately normalized). The key insight is that the interval $[0, 1]$ can be viewed as a *sub-domain* of the torus $\mathbb{T}^1$ (identified with $[-1, 1]$) subject to a symmetry constraint. While the torus possesses full translation invariance, the interval possesses *reflection invariance*. By imposing a symmetry on the torus, we create “virtual boundaries” at the fixed points of the reflection ($x = 0$ and $x = 1$). This gives rise to two distinct orthonormal bases for $L^2([0, 1])$, each corresponding to a different physical boundary condition:

- *Odd Symmetry (Dirichlet Conditions)*: Consider the subspace of functions on $\mathbb{T}^1$ that are *odd*, satisfying $u(-x) = -u(x)$. At the fixed point $x = 0$, this symmetry forces $u(0) = -u(0)$, implying $u(0) = 0$. Physically, the heat flowing from the right is perfectly cancelled by the “negative heat” flowing from the left, creating a virtual cold wall. The eigenfunctions respecting this symmetry are precisely the sine functions:

$$\sin(n\pi x) = \frac{e^{in\pi x} - e^{-in\pi x}}{2i}$$

Restricting these functions to $[0, 1]$ yields the *Sine Basis*, which diagonalizes the Laplacian subject to $u(0) = u(1) = 0$.

- *Even Symmetry (Neumann Conditions)*: Consider the subspace of functions on $\mathbb{T}^1$ that are *even*, satisfying $u(-x) = u(x)$. At the fixed point, the derivative must be odd, forcing $u'(0) = 0$. Physically, this represents an insulated boundary where heat reflects back without loss. The eigenfunctions respecting this symmetry are the cosine functions:

$$\cos(n\pi x) = \frac{e^{in\pi x} + e^{-in\pi x}}{2}$$

Restricting these to $[0, 1]$ yields the *Cosine Basis*, which diagonalizes the Laplacian subject to $u'(0) = u'(1) = 0$.

This leads to a result in Harmonic Analysis known as *half-range expansions*: while sines and cosines *together* form a basis for the full torus, *either* set alone forms a complete orthonormal basis for the interval $[0, 1]$.

Decoupling PDE

To understand the consequences better, take a solution $u : \mathbb{T}^1 \times [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$. Then, think of each (space) neighborhood in the usual heat equation as influencing its infinitesimal neighbourhood, namely the $\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2}$ term determines how each neighbouring point affects each other as time propagates. We can think of this as being uncountably many dependent equations.

Let us now change the “basis” of our state space from the position basis $\{\delta_x\}_{x \in \mathbb{T}^1}$ to the eigenbasis of the spatial operator $\{e^{ikx}\}_{k \in \mathbb{Z}}$. By taking the Fourier transform, i.e. transforming to the translation-invariant orthonormal basis, we change a solution to:

$$u(x, t) : \mathbb{T}^1 \times [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{C} \quad \xrightarrow{\mathcal{F}_x} \quad \hat{u}(k, t) : \mathbb{Z} \times [0, \infty) \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$$

where the $\mathbb{Z}$ is the index for the eigenbasis $\{f_k\}_{k \in \mathbb{Z}}$. Then if $\hat{u}_k$ is the function whose input is the index of the eigenvector and output is its coefficient, we see that as $\hat{u}_k$ propagates through time, $\hat{u}_k(t)$ is only dependent on the original function up to scaling. In fact we shall show that the heat equation PDE decomposes into the equations:

$$\frac{d\hat{u}_k}{dt} = -k^2 \hat{u}_k \quad \forall k \in \mathbb{Z}$$

where now we have *countably many decoupled* equations.

Non-Compact Domain

Notice that $\sin, \cos, e^z$ are not L^2 -integrable on $\mathbb{R}^n$ (resp. $\mathbb{C}^n$), hence these cannot form an orthonormal basis on $L^2(\mathbb{R}^n)$. Thus, the initial foray into Fourier will focus on functions with domain $\mathbb{T}^n$. In section 1.2.2 we shall show how to generalize the tools to the non-compact case, more specifically, the locally compact case.

Digression to Lie Theory

We have established that the Fourier basis functions e^{ikx} are the eigenfunctions of the “global” spatial translation operator τ_a . However, the reader likely recognizes these functions primarily as the solutions to the differential equation $f' = \lambda f$. This connection between the *global* translation τ_a and the *local* derivative $D = \frac{d}{dx}$ is a central theme of Lie Theory.

In chapter 2, it shall be shown that it makes sense to infinitely differentiate integrable functions. For now, we rely on the intuition that any continuous function can be approximated by a smooth function (and locally by a polynomial).

Consider the Taylor expansion of a function f around a point x :

$$f(z) = f(x) + f'(x)(z - x) + \frac{f''(x)}{2!}(z - x)^2 + \dots$$

If we wish to evaluate f at a shifted point $x + y$, the Taylor series gives:

$$f(x + y) = f(x) + yf'(x) + \frac{y^2}{2!}f''(x) + \dots$$

Notice that we can re-write this using the differentiation operator $D = \frac{d}{dx}$:

$$f(x + y) = \left(I + yD + \frac{y^2 D^2}{2!} + \dots \right) f(x)$$

Recognizing the series inside the parenthesis as the definition of the matrix exponential, we arrive at the compact operator identity:

$$\tau_y = e^{yD}$$

This equation states that *differentiation generates translation*.

Now, consider the spectral consequences. If an operator A has an eigenvector v with eigenvalue λ ($Av = \lambda v$), then the operator exponential e^A acts on v as:

$$e^A v = \left(I + A + \frac{A^2}{2!} + \dots \right) v = \left(1 + \lambda + \frac{\lambda^2}{2!} + \dots \right) v = e^{\lambda} v$$

Applying this to our spatial operators: since $f(x) = e^{ikx}$ is an eigenfunction of the derivative D with eigenvalue ik (i.e., $De^{ikx} = ike^{ikx}$), it must automatically be an eigenfunction of the translation operator $\tau_y = e^{yD}$ with eigenvalue e^{iyk} .

This confirms our earlier finding: the Fourier basis e^{ikx} simultaneously diagonalizes the derivative (and by extension the Laplacian $\Delta = D^2$) and the translation group.

Theorem 1.2.1: Spectral Mapping Theorem

Any eigenvector with eigenvalue λ of an operator A is an eigenvector of the operator e^A with eigenvalue e^λ .

Proof:

Follows from the power series definition of the matrix exponential shown above.

To see this explicitly, observe the action of these operators on the basis function $f_k(x) = e^{ikx}$:

- *Derivative*: $Df_k = (ik)f_k$ (Eigenvalue ik)
- *Laplacian*: $\Delta f_k = D^2 f_k = (ik)^2 f_k = -k^2 f_k$ (Eigenvalue $-k^2$)
- *Translation*: $\tau_a f_k = e^{aD} f_k = e^{a(ik)} f_k$ (Eigenvalue e^{ika})

In the language of representation theory, the differentiation operator is the *Lie Algebra* generator $\mathfrak{g}$, and the translation operator is the *Lie Group* element $e^{\mathfrak{g}}$. The Fourier basis provides the unique coordinate system where the group action and its generator are both simple scalings.

Generalizing using Representation Theory

In the previous section, our motivation was to solve a specific time-dependent PDE (the heat equation). We discovered that the key to solving it lay not in the time evolution S_t itself, but in the underlying symmetry of the spatial domain (translation invariance). The basis functions e^{ikx} worked because they diagonalized the translation operator τ_a .

We now abstract this principle. We no longer need a specific “time” equation; instead, we look for the basis that diagonalizes the action of the symmetry group itself. By finding the irreducible representations of the symmetry group, we construct a “universal” eigenbasis that will automatically diagonalize *any* linear operator respecting that symmetry (be it the Laplacian, the Heat Operator, or others).

To make this concrete, let us recall the representation theory of finite groups. If G is a finite group, we can represent G on a vector space V (over a field k) by taking a homomorphism $\rho : G \rightarrow \text{GL}(V)$.

$$G \curvearrowright V \quad \rho(g)v = g \cdot v$$

As we are not interested in any arithmetic limitations, we take $k = \mathbb{C}$. Then by Maschke’s theorem (see [NateAlgebra]) the induced $\mathbb{C}[G]$ -module structure on V is semi-simple, meaning:

$$V \cong_G \bigoplus_i V_i$$

where V_i are irreducible representations. Given the basis for the above isomorphism, any $g \in G$ will give a matrix representation $\rho(g)$ which respects this block-diagonal decomposition:

$$\rho(g) = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{M}_1(g) & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \mathbf{M}_2(g) & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \mathbf{M}_3(g) & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \dots \end{bmatrix}$$

where $\mathbf{M}_i(g)$ represents the matrix block acting on the subspace V_i . Crucially, if G is *abelian*, Schur's Lemma implies that *all* irreducible representations are 1-dimensional. Hence, the matrices become scalars:

$$\rho(g) = \begin{bmatrix} \lambda_1(g) & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & \lambda_2(g) & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & \lambda_3(g) & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & \dots \end{bmatrix}$$

As each $\rho(g)$ is representable by a diagonal matrix using the same basis, the operators $\{\rho(g)\}_{g \in G}$ are a commuting family of linear operators (i.e. they are *simultaneously diagonalizable*).

Now, we generalize this to function spaces. While for a finite group the vector space of functions $\mathbb{C}[G]$ is finite-dimensional, equipping it with an inner product structure is essential to define unitarity and orthogonality. A finite group G carries a natural unique measure (the counting measure), which we can normalize to be a probability measure (the Haar measure $\mu(g) = 1/|G|$). This allows us to define the Hilbert space $L^2(G)$ with inner product:

$$\langle f, h \rangle = \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{x \in G} f(x) \overline{h(x)}$$

We define the *Right Regular Representation*⁸ of G on this space:

$$G \curvearrowright L^2(G) \quad (R_g \cdot f)(x) = f(xg)$$

We verify that this action is unitary (and hence can be diagonalized with an orthonormal basis). Since right-multiplication by g is a bijection on the group G (it permutes the elements), the sum over x is identical to the sum over $y = xg$:

$$\begin{aligned} \langle R_g f, R_g h \rangle &= \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{x \in G} f(xg) \overline{h(xg)} \\ &= \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{y \in G} f(y) \overline{h(y)} \\ &= \langle f, h \rangle \end{aligned}$$

Thus, the operators R_g are unitary. Since G is abelian, the operators $\{R_g\}_{g \in G}$ form a commuting family of unitary operators. By the spectral theorem for unitary operators, there exists an orthonormal basis $\mathcal{B}$ of $L^2(G)$ that simultaneously diagonalizes the action. If $\varphi \in \mathcal{B}$ is such a basis vector, then:

$$R_g(\varphi) = \chi_\varphi(g)\varphi$$

where $\chi_\varphi(g) \in \mathbb{C}$ is the eigenvalue. Since the representation is a homomorphism ($R_{gh} = R_g R_h$), the eigenvalues must satisfy the multiplicative property $\chi_\varphi(gh) = \chi_\varphi(g)\chi_\varphi(h)$. Moreover, since R_g is unitary, $|\chi_\varphi(g)| = 1$ and hence the codomain is S^1 . These homomorphisms $\chi : G \rightarrow S^1$ are precisely the *characters* of the group. Thus,

the group-theoretic eigenbasis for $L^2(G)$ is simply the set of characters!

We shall explore this more in section 3.2.

⁸or, Left Regular Representations $(L_g \cdot f)(x) = f(g^{-1}x)$

1.2.2 Advanced: Operators Commuting with Translations We focused on finding the basis that diagonalizes translations (R_g) . But what are the operators that commute with all translations?

$$T \circ R_g = R_g \circ T \quad \forall g \in G$$

A fundamental result in Harmonic Analysis states that any such linear operator T is a *Convolution Operator*. That is, there exists a function $k \in L^1(G)$ (the kernel) such that $Tf = f * k$. This explains why the Heat Operator, the Laplacian, and other physical operators can all be written as convolutions: they are simply the most general linear maps that respect the symmetry of the space.

The Infinite Compact Case

In the case where the domain is infinite (like the torus $\mathbb{T}^n$), we must be more careful. First, let us stick to compact domains so that we generalize the finite case directly. Functions defined on a rectangular domain with periodic boundary conditions are equivalent to functions on the torus $\mathbb{T}^n = (S^1)^n$. Our state space is the Hilbert space $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n, \mathbb{C})$.

We want to act by translation by $\mathbb{R}^n$, but since the domain is periodic, this descends to a faithful action of the compact group $\mathbb{R}^n/\mathbb{Z}^n \cong \mathbb{T}^n$. It is easy to check that translation is unitary ($\langle \tau_y f, \tau_y g \rangle = \langle f, g \rangle$) using the translation invariance of the Lebesgue measure.

We now invoke the *Peter-Weyl Theorem*, which is the generalization of Maschke's theorem to compact topological groups (see [NateGeoRepTheory]). It states that the unitary representation of a compact group on $L^2(G)$ decomposes into a Hilbert direct sum of finite-dimensional irreducible representations:

$$L^2(G) \cong_G \widehat{\bigoplus_i V_i}$$

Since $\mathbb{T}^n$ is abelian, all irreducible representations V_i are *one-dimensional*. Being one-dimensional and unitary, they are given by characters $\chi : \mathbb{T}^n \rightarrow S^1$.

Thus, the Peter-Weyl theorem guarantees that the characters of $\mathbb{T}^n$ form a complete orthonormal basis for $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$. We have recovered our Fourier basis purely from the algebraic structure of the domain, without reference to any specific differential equation!

1.2.1 Fourier Transform on n-Torus

Finally, we look at the details and formally define the Fourier transform. Let us first formalize the eigenvectors of the translation operator:

Theorem 1.2.3: Eigenvector of Translation Functions

Let φ be a measurable function on $\mathbb{R}^n$ (resp. $\mathbb{T}^n$) such that $\varphi(x+y) = \varphi(x)\varphi(y)$ and $|\varphi(x)| = 1$. Then there exists a $\xi \in \mathbb{R}^n$ (resp. $\xi \in \mathbb{T}^n$) such that $\varphi(x) = e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x}$ where $\xi \cdot x$ is the dot product.

Proof:

We prove it for $\mathbb{R}$, the result naturally generalizing for $\mathbb{R}^n$ and automatically working for $\mathbb{T}^n$. Let $a \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $\int_0^a \varphi(t)dt \neq 0$. Such an a exists, or else by the Lebesgue Differentiation Theorem $\varphi = 0$ a.e. Setting $A = \left(\int_0^a \varphi(t)dt\right)^{-1}$, we get:

$$\varphi(x) = \varphi(x)AA^{-1} = A \int_0^a \varphi(x)\varphi(t)dx = A \int_0^a \varphi(x+t)dt = A \int_x^{x+a} \varphi(t)dt$$

Thus, φ must be continuous, being the integral of a locally integrable function. But that makes the function inside the integral continuous, and so φ is in fact C^1 (in fact C^∞ , but we will not need this fact). Now, notice that:

$$\varphi'(x) = A[\varphi(x+a) - \varphi(x)] = B\varphi(x)$$

where $B = A(\varphi(a) - 1)$. This is a simple ODE, which can be solved to show we get an exponential (and is unique by the uniqueness of a solution to an ODE). If you don't know about ODEs, then notice that

$$\frac{d}{dx}(e^{-Bx}\varphi(x)) = 0$$

so $e^{-Bx}\varphi(x)$ is constant. Since $\varphi(0) = 1$, we have $\varphi(x) = e^{Bx}$, and since $|\varphi(x)| = 1$, B must be purely imaginary meaning $B = 2\pi i\xi$ for some $\xi \in \mathbb{R}$, completing the proof for $\mathbb{R}$. For $\mathbb{T}$, we would consider φ to be periodic with period 1 and $e^{2\pi i\xi} = 1$ if and only if $\xi \in \mathbb{Z}$

For the n -dimensional case, let $e_1, e_2, \dots, e_n$ be the standard basis for $\mathbb{R}^n$ and define the coordinate functions $\varphi_i(t) = \varphi(te_i)$. Naturally, each φ_i satisfies the property $\varphi_i(t+s) = \varphi_i(t)\varphi_i(s)$ on $\mathbb{R}$, and so $\varphi_i(t) = e^{2\pi i\xi_i t}$, and so:

$$\varphi(x) = \varphi\left(\sum_{i=1}^n x_i e_i\right) = \prod_{i=1}^n \varphi_i(x_i) = e^{2\pi i\xi \cdot x}$$

completing the proof.

Hence, a function satisfying this translation invariance is of the form $f(x) = ce^{2\pi i\xi \cdot x}$ for some constant $c \in \mathbb{R}$. With the classification of these functions, we will want to use these to decompose reasonably arbitrary functions in $\mathbb{R}^n$ and $\mathbb{T}^n$ (i.e. we will show they form a dense set). In the case of L^2 with $\mathbb{T}^n$, we get a very precise result:

Theorem 1.2.4: Orthonormality Of Translation Functions

Let $E_k(x) = e^{2\pi i k \cdot x}$. Then the set $\{E_k \mid k \in \mathbb{Z}^n\}$ is an orthonormal basis for $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$

Proof:

For orthonormality, notice that:

$$\int_0^1 e^{2\pi i k t} dt = \begin{cases} 1 & k = 0 \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

using this, notice that if $n \neq m$, then:

$$\begin{aligned}\langle E_a, E_b \rangle &= \int_0^1 e^{2\pi i a t} \overline{e^{2\pi i b t}} dt \\ &= \int_0^1 e^{2\pi i (a-b)t} dt \\ &= \frac{1}{2\pi i (a-b)} (e^{2\pi i (a-b)} - e^0) \\ &= \frac{1}{2\pi i (a-b)} (1 - 1) \\ &= 0\end{aligned}$$

and if $n = m$, then we get

$$\int_0^1 e^{2\pi i k t} \overline{e^{2\pi i k t}} dt = \int_0^1 1 dt = 1$$

For density, since $E_x E_y = E_{x+y}$, the set of finite linear combinations of the E_k 's form an algebra which clearly separates points on $\mathbb{T}^n$, and $E_0 = 1$, $\overline{E_k} = E_{-k}$. Since $\mathbb{T}^n$ compact, by the Stone-Weierstrass theorem, this algebra is dense in $C(\mathbb{T}^n)$ in the uniform norm and hence in the L^2 norm, and $C(\mathbb{T}^n)$ is dense in $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$, and so $\{E_k\}$ is an orthonormal basis for $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$, as we sought to show.

Using this, we can now define the Fourier transform:

Definition 1.2.5: Fourier Transform And Fourier Series on Torus

Let $f \in L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$, $\langle -, - \rangle$ be the induced inner product, and E_k the orthonormal basis from theorem 1.2.4. Then the *Fourier Transform* $\hat{f} : \mathbb{Z}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ is the function defined as:

$$\hat{f}(k) = \langle f, E_k \rangle = \int_{\mathbb{T}^n} f(x) e^{-2\pi i k \cdot x} dx$$

The map $f \mapsto \hat{f}$ is called the *Fourier transform*. The representation

$$f = \sum_{k \in \mathbb{Z}^n} \hat{f}(k) E_k$$

is called the *Fourier series* of f .

Example 1.2.6: Discrete Spectrum Examples (Torus)

1. *The Pure Tone (Finite Spectrum)*: Let $f(x) = \sin(2\pi m x)$ for some integer m . Using Euler's identity:

$$f(x) = \frac{e^{2\pi i m x} - e^{-2\pi i m x}}{2i}$$

The Fourier transform is a pair of spikes: $\hat{f}(m) = \frac{1}{2i}$, $\hat{f}(-m) = -\frac{1}{2i}$, and $\hat{f}(k) = 0$ everywhere else. A smooth, oscillating function on the torus has a *finite* number of non-zero coefficients.

2. *The Square Wave (Algebraic Decay)*: Consider the periodic function equal to $+1$ on $[0, 1/2)$

and -1 on $[1/2, 1)$.

$$\hat{f}(k) = \frac{1 - (-1)^k}{\pi i k} \quad \text{for } k \neq 0$$

This gives non-zero values only for odd k , decaying as $1/k$. Discontinuities in the function lead to coefficients that decay slowly (algebraically). This slow decay causes the partial sums to oscillate violently near the jump (Gibbs Phenomenon).

3. *The Periodized Gaussian (Jacobi Theta Function)*: Instead of a single Gaussian (which doesn't live on a torus), we sum infinitely many copies:

$$f(x) = \sum_{n \in \mathbb{Z}} e^{-\pi(x-n)^2}$$

Remarkably, the Fourier series coefficients are sampled from the Gaussian itself:

$$\hat{f}(k) = e^{-\pi k^2}$$

This connects local geometry to global geometry. Even though the function wraps around the circle, its coefficients still decay super-fast (exponentially), reflecting the smoothness of the function.

4. *The Dirac Comb (Flat Spectrum)*: Let $f = \delta_0$ be the Dirac delta distribution at the origin (periodized).

$$\hat{f}(k) = \int_{\mathbb{T}} \delta_0(x) e^{-2\pi i k x} dx = 1$$

Extreme localization in space (a single point) leads to extreme delocalization in frequency (all frequencies contribute equally).

By the definition of an orthonormal basis, the Fourier series of f converges to f in the L^2 -norm. In the next sections, we will address point-wise convergence. As this is simply a conversion of basis:

Theorem 1.2.7: Parseval's Identity On $\mathbb{T}^n$

$$\|\hat{f}\|_2 = \|f\|_2$$

Proof:

Theorem 1.2.4 shows that $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$ surjects onto $\ell^2(\mathbb{Z}^n)$ and forms an orthonormal basis, hence by ??

$$\|\hat{f}\|_2 = \|f\|_2$$

Let us take some time concretely interpreting $\hat{f}(k)$. First, $\hat{f}(0)$ represents the “average total energy” in the system:

$$\hat{f}(0) = \int_{\mathbb{T}^n} f(x) dx$$

where as $m(\mathbb{T}^n) = 1$ the normalization is hidden. If we visualized this, we can think of it as the center of mass of the graph of a compact function wrapped around the circle. Then $\hat{f}(n)$ for $n \in \mathbb{Z}^k$ is that same graph wrapped around in each cardinal direction n_i number of times, and then taking

its average:

$$\hat{f}(n) = \int_{\mathbb{T}^n} f(x) e^{2\pi i x \cdot n} dx$$

Now, let's say that instead of trying to take the formal approach we've done, we motivate the coefficient formula geometrically. Consider the inner product as a projection that will project onto one of the axis given by one of the terms in the series:

$$f = \dots + c_{-1}e^{-1 \cdot 2\pi i t} + c_0e^{0 \cdot 2\pi i t} + c_1e^{1 \cdot 2\pi i t} + c_2e^{2 \cdot 2\pi i t} + \dots$$

How do we find the coefficients? First, by the DCT:

$$\begin{aligned} \int f(t) dt &= \int (\dots + c_{-1}e^{-1 \cdot 2\pi i t} + c_0e^{0 \cdot 2\pi i t} + c_1e^{1 \cdot 2\pi i t} + c_2e^{2 \cdot 2\pi i t}) dt \\ &= \dots + \int c_{-1}e^{-1 \cdot 2\pi i t} dt + \int c_0e^{0 \cdot 2\pi i t} dt + \int c_1e^{1 \cdot 2\pi i t} dt + \int c_2e^{2 \cdot 2\pi i t} dt + \dots \end{aligned}$$

Now, notice that all terms except the one containing c_0 are disappear, since the rotation of by the exponential will always guarantee to make the integrals average to zero! Thus, c_0 can be thought of as the average mass point of f . To find the other terms, we simply have to multiply f at the beginning by $e^{k2\pi i t}$

$$\int f(t) e^{-k2\pi i t} dt$$

and then we have shifted over all of our terms except the k th term, which we can now find the integral of! In fact, notice we have just recovered:

$$\hat{f}(k) = \int f(t) e^{-k2\pi i t} dt$$

giving us a geometric intuition for this formula!

Now, this gives the Fourier transform on $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n, \mathbb{C})$, but we often want to work with different L^p spaces. First, the definition of the Fourier transform $\hat{f}(k)$ makes sense if $f \in L^1(\mathbb{T}^n)$ since:

$$|\hat{f}(\xi)| = \left| \int f(x) e^{2\pi i x \cdot \xi} dx \right| \leq \int |f(x) e^{2\pi i x \cdot \xi}| dx = \int |f(x)| dx = \|f\|_1$$

Hence for each $\xi \in \mathbb{Z}^n$, if $f \in L^1(\mathbb{T}^n)$ then $|\hat{f}(\xi)| \leq \|f\|_1$ showing us that $\hat{f}$ must be essentially bounded:

$$\|\hat{f}\|_\infty$$

so the Fourier series would then extend to a norm-decreasing map from $L^1(\mathbb{T}^n)$ to $\ell^\infty(\mathbb{Z}^n)$. In particular, this shows us that there is a sort of duality between the speed of decay of a function f and its Fourier transform $\hat{f}$. The nature of this duality is made explicit in the following theorem:

Theorem 1.2.8: Hausdorff-Young Inequality over $\mathbb{T}^n$

Let $1 \leq p \leq 2$ and q be the conjugate exponent of p so that $\frac{1}{p} + \frac{1}{q} = 1$. If $f \in L^p(\mathbb{T}^n)$, then

$$\hat{f} \in \ell^q(\mathbb{Z}^n) \quad \text{and} \quad \|\hat{f}\|_q \leq \|f\|_p$$

Proof:

Since $\|\hat{f}\|_\infty \leq \|f\|_1$ and $\|\hat{f}\|_2 = \|f\|_2$ for $f \in L^1$ and $f \in L^2$, this follows from the Riesz-Thorin interpolation theorem (??)

Example 1.2.9: Advanced: The Theta Function and Modularity

1. *The Heat Kernel Trace:* Recall example 1.2.6.3, where we periodized the Gaussian to get $K_t(x) = \sum_{n \in \mathbb{Z}} e^{-\pi n^2 t} e^{2\pi i n x}$. If we evaluate this at the identity ($x = 0$), we obtain the classical *Theta Function* $\theta(it)$:

$$\theta(it) = \sum_{n \in \mathbb{Z}} e^{-\pi n^2 t}$$

In the language of Number Theory, this is a modular form (specifically of weight $1/2$). The fact that the Fourier transform of a Gaussian is a Gaussian translates directly into the *functional equation* of the Theta function via the Poisson Summation Formula:

$$\theta(t^{-1}) = \sqrt{t} \theta(t)$$

This identity is the “analytic engine” that proves the analytic continuation of the Riemann Zeta function $\zeta(s)$.

2. *Gauss Sums (Arithmetic Fourier Transform):* If we replace our field $\mathbb{C}$ with a finite field $\mathbb{F}_p$ and our torus with the additive group of the field, the Fourier Transform becomes the *Gauss Sum*:

$$g(a) = \sum_{x \in \mathbb{F}_p} \chi(x) e^{2\pi i a x / p}$$

Just as $\int |f|^2 = \int |\hat{f}|^2$ (Plancherel), we have $|g(a)| = \sqrt{p}$. The “square root cancellation” of Fourier coefficients in analytic number theory is the discrete analogue of the decay rates we study in analysis.

1.2.2 Fourier Transform on Euclidean Space

We often want to work with $L^2(\mathbb{R}^n)$. The problem is that $e^{2\pi i k \cdot}$ is *not* an element of $L^2(\mathbb{R}^n)$ as its integral is infinite. To generalize the domain to $\mathbb{R}^n$, we need to shift perspectives. Recall that all unitary representation of $\mathbb{T}^n$ are given by functions in:

$$\text{Hom}(\mathbb{T}^n, S^1) \cong \mathbb{Z}^n$$

This is the *Pontryagin dual* of $\mathbb{T}^n$ and represents all the characters. We can generalize this and choose a locally compact (topological) groups and consider the Pontryagin dual $\text{Hom}(G, S^1)$. As shall be shown in chapter 3, there shall always be a unique invariant Borel measure defined on any locally compact group up to scaling (ex. on $\mathbb{R}$ it is the Lebesgue measure and on $\mathbb{Z}$ it is the counting measure). It can be shown that $\text{Hom}(G, S^1)$ is also a locally compact group and hence has a unique measure. When G is compact, $\text{Hom}(G, S^1)$ is *discrete* and the natural Haar measure is the counting measure. If G is not compact but locally compact, $\text{Hom}(G, S^1)$ is *continuous*, most importantly:

$$\text{Hom}(\mathbb{R}^d, S^1) \cong \mathbb{R}^d \quad \text{given by} \quad (\xi \mapsto e^{2\pi i x \cdot \xi}) \mapsto x$$

Notice that if G is compact and abelian, $\text{Hom}(G, S^1)$ represents all the characters. Hence if G is *locally compact*, then $\hat{G} = \text{Hom}(G, S^1)$, can be interpreted as the generalization of characters.

1.2.10 Advanced: The Notion of Points If you have seen Grothendieck's notion of the *Functor of Points*, then the “right” way to see points is not as elements of a set, but as *morphisms* from a test object. In algebraic geometry, a point of a scheme X is determined by the morphisms $T \rightarrow X$. In harmonic analysis, this philosophy manifests as *Tannaka-Krein Duality*. We can reconstruct a group G solely from its category of representations $\text{Rep}(G)$. A “geometric point” $g \in G$ corresponds precisely to a tensor automorphism of the fiber functor (the forgetful functor to vector spaces). Thus, the Fourier Transform is simply the mechanism that translates between the geometric perspective (points as elements) and the spectral perspective (points as representations), proving they are dual aspects of the same underlying structure.

We can thus generalize the orthonormal basis interpretation of the Fourier transform to

$$\mathcal{F} : L^2(G, \mathbb{C}) \rightarrow L^2(\hat{G}, \mathbb{C})$$

Of course we have not proven it is well-defined, namely since $\hat{G}$ need not be an orthonormal basis anymore. For example if $f \in L^2(\mathbb{R}^d)$, it is not necessarily the case that $f \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^d)$ however as we've defined it so far we integrate against $e^{2\pi i x \cdot \xi}$:

$$\hat{f}(\xi) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x) e^{2\pi i x \cdot \xi} dx$$

Simply take $(1 + |x|)^{-1} \in L^2(\mathbb{R})$ which not in $L^1(\mathbb{R})$. However, $\mathcal{F}$ shall still be a well-defined map between L^2 spaces as shall be shown in upcoming sections. Note that in the case of $G = \mathbb{T}^n$ this is exactly what we had before:

$$\mathcal{F} : L^2(\mathbb{T}^n, \mathbb{C}) \rightarrow \ell^2(\mathbb{Z}^n, \mathbb{C})$$

There is a lot of details that are brushed off for now; this is all covered in chapter 3.

Now, if $f \in L^1$, $\hat{f}(\xi)$ will certainly be bounded (by $\|f\|_1$), and hence it is essentially bounded:

$$\|\mathcal{F}(f)\|_\infty < \infty$$

We thus have our first definition of Fourier transform on $\mathbb{R}^d$:

Definition 1.2.11: Fourier Transform on L^1

Let $f \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$. Then the *Fourier Transform* $\hat{f} : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ is the function defined as:

$$\hat{f}(\xi) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx$$

The map $f \mapsto \hat{f}$ is called the *Fourier transform*.

As it turns out, $\mathcal{F}(f)$ is also continuous, hence it is not only essentially bounded (in L^∞) but *actually* bounded (in BC):

Theorem 1.2.12: Riemann-Lebesgue Lemma

$$\mathcal{F}(L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)) \subseteq BC(\mathbb{R}^n)$$

Proof:

Let $f \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ and consider $\{\xi_k\}_{k=1}^\infty \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ such that $\xi_k \rightarrow \xi$. It suffices to show $\lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} \hat{f}(\xi_k) = \hat{f}(\xi)$.

By the definition of the Fourier transform,

$$\hat{f}(\xi_k) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi_k \cdot x} dx.$$

Let $F_k(x) = f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi_k \cdot x}$. Since the complex exponential is continuous, we have pointwise convergence for every $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$:

$$\lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} F_k(x) = f(x) \lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} e^{-2\pi i \xi_k \cdot x} = f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}.$$

Next, for all k and x , the integrand is bounded by the magnitude of f :

$$|F_k(x)| = |f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi_k \cdot x}| = |f(x)| \cdot 1 = |f(x)|.$$

Since $f \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$, $|f|$ dominates it. Thus, by the DCT:

$$\lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} F_k(x) dx = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} \lim_{k \rightarrow \infty} F_k(x) dx = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx = \hat{f}(\xi).$$

showing $\hat{f}$ is continuous, as we sought to show.

Proposition 1.2.13: Properties Of Fourier Transform

Let $f, g \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$. Then:

1. $\widehat{(\tau_y f)}(\xi) = e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot y} \hat{f}(\xi)$ and $\tau_\eta(\hat{f}) = \hat{h}$ where $h(x) = e^{2\pi i \eta \cdot x} f(x)$
2. If T is an invertible linear transformation on $\mathbb{R}^n$ and $S = (T^*)^{-1}$ is its inverse transpose, Then $\widehat{(f \circ T)} = |\det(T)|^{-1} \hat{f} \circ S$. In particular, if T is a rotation, then $\widehat{(f \circ T)} = \hat{f} \circ T$. Furthermore, if $T(x) = t^{-1}x$ (for $t > 0$), then $\widehat{(f \circ T)}(\xi) = t^n \hat{f}(t\xi)$.

Note: This implies the Heisenberg Uncertainty Principle qualitatively: dilating (widening) f results in contracting (narrowing) $\hat{f}$.

3. Convolution becomes multiplication after the Fourier Transform:

$$\widehat{(f * g)} = \hat{f} \hat{g}$$

4. (*Conjugate Symmetry*) if f is real-valued, then $\hat{f}$ (which is still complex-valued) satisfies the Hermitian symmetry condition:

$$\hat{f}(-\xi) = \overline{\hat{f}(\xi)}$$

This implies the information in the codomain is 'half' redundant.

5. If $x^\alpha f \in L^1$ for $|\alpha| \leq k$ then $\hat{f} \in C^k$ and

$$\partial^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi) = [(-2\pi i x)^\alpha f](\xi)$$

6. if $f \in C^k$, $\partial^\alpha f \in L^1$ for $|\alpha| \leq k$, and $\partial^\alpha f \in C_0$, for $|\alpha| \leq k-1$, then

$$\widehat{(\partial^\alpha f)}(\xi) = (2\pi i \xi)^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi)$$

7. upgraded Riemann-Lebesgue lemma:

$$\mathcal{F}(L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)) \subseteq C_0(\mathbb{R}^n)$$

Proof:

1. Computing directly:

$$\widehat{(\tau_y f)}(\xi) = \int f(x-y) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx$$

Let $z = x - y$, then $dx = dz$ and $x = z + y$:

$$= \int f(z) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot (z+y)} dz = e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot y} \int f(z) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot z} dz = e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot y} \hat{f}(\xi)$$

For the second part, let $h(x) = e^{2\pi i \eta \cdot x} f(x)$.

$$\hat{h}(\xi) = \int e^{2\pi i \eta \cdot x} f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx = \int f(x) e^{-2\pi i (\xi - \eta) \cdot x} dx = \hat{f}(\xi - \eta) = \tau_\eta(\hat{f})(\xi)$$

2. Apply theorem ?? (Change of Variables). Let $y = Tx$, then $x = T^{-1}y$ and $dx = |\det T|^{-1}dy$:

$$\begin{aligned}\widehat{(f \circ T)}(\xi) &= \int f(Tx) \exp(-2\pi i \xi \cdot x) dx \\ &= |\det T|^{-1} \int f(y) \exp(-2\pi i \xi \cdot T^{-1}y) dy\end{aligned}$$

Using the definition of the adjoint (transpose), $\xi \cdot T^{-1}y = (T^{-1})^* \xi \cdot y = S\xi \cdot y$:

$$\begin{aligned}&= |\det T|^{-1} \int f(y) \exp(-2\pi i S\xi \cdot y) dy \\ &= |\det T|^{-1} \hat{f}(S\xi)\end{aligned}$$

3. By Fubini's Theorem (justified since $f, g \in L^1$):

$$\begin{aligned}\widehat{(f * g)}(\xi) &= \int \left(\int f(x-y)g(y)dy \right) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx \\ &= \int g(y) \left(\int f(x-y)e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx \right) dy\end{aligned}$$

Applying the translation property (proven in 1) to the inner integral where f is translated by y :

$$\begin{aligned}&= \int g(y) \left(e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot y} \hat{f}(\xi) \right) dy \\ &= \hat{f}(\xi) \int g(y) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot y} dy \\ &= \hat{f}(\xi) \hat{g}(\xi)\end{aligned}$$

4. exercise.

5. By Differentiating under the integral sign (justified by the Dominated Convergence Theorem and the assumption $x^\alpha f \in L^1$):

$$\partial^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi) = \partial_\xi^\alpha \int f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx = \int f(x) \partial_\xi^\alpha (e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}) dx = \int f(x) (-2\pi i x)^\alpha e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx$$

6. Assuming first that $n = 1$ and $k = 1$. Since $f \in C_0$, f vanishes at boundaries. We integrate by parts:

$$\hat{f}'(\xi) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f'(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi x} dx$$

Let $u = e^{-2\pi i \xi x}$ and $dv = f'(x)dx$. Then $du = -2\pi i \xi e^{-2\pi i \xi x} dx$ and $v = f(x)$.

$$= [f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi x}]_{-\infty}^{\infty} - \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) (-2\pi i \xi) e^{-2\pi i \xi x} dx$$

The boundary term is 0 because $f \in C_0$.

$$= 2\pi i \xi \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi x} dx = 2\pi i \xi \hat{f}(\xi)$$

For $n > 1$, we compute $\widehat{(\partial_j f)}$ by integrating by parts with respect to the j -th variable x_j . The boundary terms vanish because $f \in C_0(\mathbb{R}^n)$. The general case follows by induction on $|\alpha|$.

7. By the previous part, if $f \in C_c^1$ (Compactly supported C^1 functions), then $\widehat{\partial_j f}(\xi) = 2\pi i \xi_j \hat{f}(\xi)$. Since $\widehat{\partial_j f}$ is bounded (as the Fourier transform of an L^1 function), $|\xi_j \hat{f}(\xi)|$ is bounded. This implies $\hat{f}(\xi)$ decays as $|\xi| \rightarrow \infty$, so $\hat{f} \in C_0$.

By a similar argument to proposition 1.1.12, C_c^1 is dense in L^1 . Let $f \in L^1$ and $f_n \in C_c^1$ such that $f_n \rightarrow f$ in L^1 . The Fourier transform is a bounded linear map from L^1 to L^∞ (specifically $\|\hat{g}\|_\infty \leq \|g\|_1$), so:

$$\|\hat{f}_n - \hat{f}\|_\infty \leq \|f_n - f\|_1 \rightarrow 0$$

Thus $\hat{f}_n \rightarrow \hat{f}$ uniformly. Since C_0 is closed under the uniform norm (a uniform limit of functions vanishing at infinity also vanishes at infinity), we conclude $\hat{f} \in C_0$.

Notice that (5) and (6) give an interesting relation between the smoothness of f and the decay of $\hat{f}$: the smoother f is, the faster $\hat{f}$ decays (and vice-versa).

Proposition 1.2.14: Regularity and Decay Duality

The smoothness of a function determines the decay of its Fourier transform, and the decay of a function determines the smoothness of its Fourier transform. In particular:

1. **Decay $\Rightarrow$ Smoothness:** If $(1 + |x|)^k f(x) \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ for some integer $k \geq 1$, then $\hat{f} \in C^k(\mathbb{R}^n)$. Specifically, differentiation converts to multiplication by a polynomial in the spatial domain:

$$\partial^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (-2\pi i x)^\alpha f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx$$

for all multi-indices $|\alpha| \leq k$.

2. **Smoothness $\Rightarrow$ Decay:** If $f \in C^k(\mathbb{R}^n)$ and $\partial^\alpha f \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ for all $|\alpha| \leq k$ (and f vanishes at infinity), then $\hat{f}$ decays rapidly:

$$|\hat{f}(\xi)| \leq \frac{C}{(1 + |\xi|)^k}$$

for some constant C .

Proof:

1. **(Decay $\Rightarrow$ Smoothness):** Formally differentiating:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial \xi_j} \hat{f}(\xi) = \frac{\partial}{\partial \xi_j} \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} f(x) \frac{\partial}{\partial \xi_j} (e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}) dx.$$

Calculating the derivative of the exponential gives $(-2\pi i x_j) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}$. Thus the integrand becomes $(-2\pi i x_j) f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}$. To justify this operation rigorously, we need a dominating function. Observe that:

$$|(-2\pi i x_j) f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}| = 2\pi |x_j| |f(x)| \leq 2\pi |x| |f(x)|.$$

By our hypothesis, $(1 + |x|)^k f \in L^1$, which implies $|x|f \in L^1$. Thus, the integrand is dominated by an integrable function, and the Dominated Convergence Theorem allows differentiation. Repeating this for higher derivatives up to order k yields the result.

2. **(Smoothness $\Rightarrow$ Decay):** We use the property that $\widehat{\partial^\alpha f}(\xi) = (2\pi i \xi)^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi)$. Since $\partial^\alpha f \in L^1$, by the standard Riemann-Lebesgue Lemma (or simply the boundedness of the Fourier transform), we know that its transform is bounded:

$$\|\widehat{\partial^\alpha f}\|_\infty \leq \|\partial^\alpha f\|_1 < \infty.$$

Substituting the identity, we have:

$$|(2\pi i \xi)^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi)| \leq \|\partial^\alpha f\|_1.$$

This implies that for any multi-index α with $|\alpha| \leq k$, the product $|\xi^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi)|$ is bounded. Since a function dominated by $1/|\xi|^k$ is equivalent to being bounded when multiplied by $|\xi|^k$, we conclude:

$$|\hat{f}(\xi)| \leq C(1 + |\xi|)^{-k}.$$

Corollary 1.2.15: Paley-Wiener theorem

If $f \in C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^n)$ has compact support (i.e., there exists $R > 0$ such that $f(x) = 0$ for $|x| > R$), then its Fourier transform $\hat{f}(\xi)$ extends to a holomorphic (complex analytic) function on $\mathbb{C}^n$.

Proof:

Let $z \in \mathbb{C}^n$. Define the complex extension of the Fourier transform as:

$$F(z) = \int_{|x| \leq R} f(x) e^{-2\pi i x \cdot z} dx$$

Since f has compact support, the integration range is effectively bounded by the ball $B_R(0)$. To show $F(z)$ is holomorphic, it suffices to show it is complex differentiable with respect to each component z_j . We compute the partial derivative by differentiating under the integral sign:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial z_j} F(z) = \int_{|x| \leq R} f(x) \frac{\partial}{\partial z_j} (e^{-2\pi i x \cdot z}) dx = \int_{|x| \leq R} f(x) (-2\pi i x_j) e^{-2\pi i x \cdot z} dx$$

To justify integral converges, let $z = \xi + i\eta$. The magnitude of the exponential term is:

$$\left| e^{-2\pi i x \cdot (\xi + i\eta)} \right| = \left| e^{-2\pi i x \cdot \xi} \right| \left| e^{2\pi x \cdot \eta} \right| = e^{2\pi x \cdot \eta}$$

Since the domain of integration is bounded ($|x| \leq R$), this term is bounded by $e^{2\pi R|\eta|}$. Furthermore, f and x_j are bounded on this domain. Thus, the integrand is bounded for any fixed z , and the integral is well-defined.

Since the derivative exists at every point $z \in \mathbb{C}^n$, the function $F(z)$ is entire (holomorphic everywhere). Consequently, the Fourier transform $\hat{f}(\xi)$ is simply the restriction of this entire function to the real subspace $\mathbb{R}^n$, implying that $\hat{f}$ is real-analytic.

Notice that $C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R}^n)$ does not map into compact spaces, since an analytic function cannot be non-zero and bounded. The closest equivalent is Schwartz space:

Corollary 1.2.16: Fourier Transform On Schwartz Space

The map $\mathcal{F}$ maps the Schwartz space $\mathcal{S}$ into itself

Proof:

If $f \in \mathcal{S}$, then $x^\alpha \partial^\beta f \in L^1 \cap C_0$ for all α, β , so by proposition 1.2.13, $\hat{f}$ is C^∞ and

$$\widehat{(x^\alpha \partial^\beta f)} = (-1)^{|\alpha|} (2\pi i)^{|\beta| - |\alpha|} \partial^\alpha (\xi^\beta \hat{f}).$$

Thus $\partial^\alpha (\xi^\beta \hat{f})$ is bounded for all α, β , whence $\hat{f} \in \mathcal{S}$. Moreover, since $\int (1 + |x|)^{-n-1} dx < \infty$,

$$\|\widehat{(x^\alpha \partial^\beta f)}\|_u \leq \|x^\alpha \partial^\beta f\|_1 \leq C \|(1 + |x|)^{n+1} x^\alpha \partial^\beta f\|_u.$$

It then follows that $\|\hat{f}\|_{(N, \beta)} \leq C_{N, \beta} \sum_{|\gamma| \leq |\beta|} \|f\|_{(N+n+1, \gamma)}$ by proposition 1.1.4, so the Fourier transform is continuous on $\mathcal{S}$.

1.2.17 Distribution Theory and Compactly Supported In distribution theory (chapter 2), it shall be shown that $C(\mathbb{R}^n)$ can be recovered by integrating against smooth functions with compact support. Thus, C_c^∞ would be ideal space for the Fourier transform *if* they mapped back to themselves. However, by the boundedness argument above it is not the case. *However*, in over totally disconnected topological groups, such as those present in the representation theory of absolute galois groups, the equivalent of Schwartz space *is* C_c^∞ ; see [NateLocalLanglands] for more details.

Example 1.2.18: Continuous Spectrum Examples (Euclidean)

1. *The Box Function (The Sinc Function)*: Let $f(x) = \mathbb{1}_{[-1/2, 1/2]}(x)$ (The indicator function of width 1).

$$\hat{f}(\xi) = \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} 1 \cdot e^{-2\pi i \xi x} dx = \frac{e^{-\pi i \xi} - e^{\pi i \xi}}{-2\pi i \xi} = \frac{\sin(\pi \xi)}{\pi \xi} \equiv \text{sinc}(\xi)$$

Unlike the Square Wave on the torus (which had discrete coefficients $1/k$), this has a

continuous spectrum that oscillates and decays as $1/\xi$. The compact support in space ($f = 0$ outside the box) forces the transform to extend infinitely (it cannot be compactly supported).

2. *The Two-Sided Exponential (Lorentzian)*: Let $f(x) = e^{-2\pi|x|}$. This is a continuous L^1 function with a "cusp" at $x = 0$.

$$\hat{f}(\xi) = \frac{1}{\pi} \frac{1}{1 + \xi^2}$$

This is the Cauchy (or Lorentzian) distribution. Notice the duality: Exponential decay in space leads to Polynomial ($1/\xi^2$) decay in frequency. The lack of smoothness at $x = 0$ (the cusp) prevents the frequency decay from being exponential.

3. *The Gaussian (Self-Dual)*: Let $f(x) = e^{-\pi x^2}$. As proven in theorem 1.3.1:

$$\hat{f}(\xi) = e^{-\pi \xi^2}$$

The Gaussian is the unique eigenfunction of the Fourier Transform. It is the perfect balance point of the Uncertainty Principle: it is equally localized in both space and frequency.

4. *The Shifted Function (Modulation)*: Let $f(x)$ be a standard Gaussian centered at $x = 100$ rather than 0: $g(x) = f(x - 100)$.

$$\hat{g}(\xi) = e^{-2\pi i(100)\xi} \hat{f}(\xi) = e^{-2\pi i 100 \xi} e^{-\pi \xi^2}$$

In Euclidean space, shifting a function far away does not change the "energy envelope" of its spectrum (it's still a Gaussian), but it causes the complex phase to wind rapidly.

Example 1.2.19: Advanced uses of Fourier Transform

1. *The Poincaré Bundle*: In our definition of the Fourier Transform $\hat{f}(\xi) = \int f(x) e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x} dx$, the kernel $K(x, \xi) = e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}$ plays the central role. In Algebraic Geometry, if A is an abelian variety (say a complex torus V/Λ), its dual $\hat{A}$ parametrizes line bundles on A . The universal line bundle $\mathcal{P}$ on $A \times \hat{A}$ (the Poincaré bundle) is the geometric geometrization of the kernel $e^{-2\pi i \xi \cdot x}$. The Fourier transform generalizes to the *Fourier-Mukai Transform*, an equivalence of derived categories of coherent sheaves:

$$\Phi_{\mathcal{P}}(\mathcal{F}^\bullet) = \mathbf{R}\pi_{2,*}(\pi_1^* \mathcal{F}^\bullet \otimes \mathcal{P})$$

Here, the integration $\int dx$ is replaced by the pushforward $\mathbf{R}\pi_{2,*}$, and the product is the tensor product.

2. *The Spectrum of the Primes (Riemann's Explicit Formula)*: You may have heard that the zeros of the Riemann Zeta function constitute the "spectrum" of the prime numbers. This is literal, not metaphorical. Consider the Chebyshev function $\psi(x) = \sum_{p^k \leq x} \log p$, which counts primes with a logarithmic weight. Riemann's Explicit Formula links this step function to the zeros $\rho = \frac{1}{2} + i\gamma$ of $\zeta(s)$:

$$\psi(x) = x - \sum_{\rho} \frac{x^{\rho}}{\rho} - \log(2\pi) - \frac{1}{2} \log(1 - x^{-2})$$

If we make the logarithmic change of variables $x = e^u$, the sum over zeros becomes:

$$\sum_{\rho} \frac{e^{u(\frac{1}{2}+i\gamma)}}{\frac{1}{2}+i\gamma} = e^{u/2} \sum_{\gamma} \left(\frac{1}{\frac{1}{2}+i\gamma} \right) e^{i\gamma u}$$

This is a Fourier series (or integral) in the variable u !

- The “time” Domain signal is the distribution of primes (spikes at $u = \log p$).
- The “Frequency” Domain is the set of imaginary parts of zeta zeros (γ).

Just as a musical chord is “recovered” by summing its constituent frequencies, the location of prime numbers is recovered by summing the waves defined by the Riemann Zeros. This duality is an instance of Fourier Duality on the ideles.

3. *Pontryagin Duality as a Moduli Problem:* We defined $\hat{G} = \text{Hom}(G, S^1)$. For a number theorist, we can view the frequency domain $\hat{G}$ as a *moduli space* of rank-1 unitary local systems on G .
 - If $G = \mathbb{R}$, the moduli space is $\mathbb{R}$ (Euclidean Fourier Transform).
 - If $G = S^1$, the moduli space is $\mathbb{Z}$ (Fourier Series).
 - If $G = \mathbb{Z}$, the moduli space is S^1 (Discrete Time Fourier Transform).

The “Duality” implies that the moduli space of the moduli space recovers the original space.

4. *The Circle Method (Diophantine Equations):* How many integer solutions are there to $n_1^k + \dots + n_s^k = N$? (Waring’s Problem). This is a combinatorial problem that Fourier Analysis turns into an analytic one. Construct the generating function (a trigonometric polynomial):

$$f(\alpha) = \sum_{m=1}^{N^{1/k}} e^{2\pi i m^k \alpha}$$

The number of solutions $R(N)$ is exactly the N -th Fourier coefficient of the function $f(\alpha)^s$:

$$R(N) = \int_0^1 (f(\alpha))^s e^{-2\pi i N \alpha} d\alpha$$

The Key insight of Hardy and Littlewood was to split this integral (the torus) into “Major Arcs” (near rational numbers with small denominators, where the sum behaves predictably) and “Minor Arcs” (where the sum oscillates and cancels out, similar to the Riemann-Lebesgue lemma).

5. *Spectral Geometry (Can You Hear the Shape of a Drum?):* The set of eigenvalues $\{\lambda_n\}$ of the Laplacian Δ on a compact Riemannian manifold (M, g) is called the *spectrum*. This is the set of “pure frequencies” the manifold can support. The Fourier Transform allows us to recover geometric data from this spectral data via the trace of the Heat Kernel:

$$\text{Tr}(e^{t\Delta}) = \sum_{n=0}^{\infty} e^{-\lambda_n t} \sim \frac{1}{(4\pi t)^{d/2}} \left(\text{Vol}(M) + \frac{t}{6} \int_M \text{Scal}_g + O(t^2) \right)$$

As $t \rightarrow 0$ (high frequencies), the asymptotics of the heat kernel allow us to “hear” the dimension, the volume, and the total scalar curvature of the manifold.

Note: Milnor gave examples of isospectral tori (16-dimensional) that are not isometric, proving that you cannot hear the *entire* shape, but Fourier analysis recovers the local invariants.

1.3 Fourier Integral and Series

Let us now show that up to measure zero the Fourier transform is injective. Equivalently, let us now look into finding the inverse Fourier transform. Let $f \in L^1$. Then define:

$$f^\vee(x) = \hat{f}(-x) = \int f(\xi) e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x} d\xi$$

We'll show that if $f, \hat{f} \in L^1$, then $(\hat{f})^\vee = f$. This cannot be done by appealing to Fubini's theorem as the integral:

$$(\hat{f})^\vee(x) = \int \int f(y) e^{2\pi i \cdot x} e^{2\pi i \cdot y} dy d\xi$$

is not in $L^1(\mathbb{R}^n \times \mathbb{R}^n)$ (it will a.e. diverge). Instead, we do the usual trick of sequences that converge to the desired values. The solution is the usual solution of taking a limit of functions that satisfy the property and insuring that the desired properties are preserved in the limit. First, a technical lemma that also has an amazing tangential property that simply must be mentioned:

Theorem 1.3.1: Fourier Transform Fixed Point

Let $f(x) = e^{-\pi a |x|^2}$ where $a > 0$. Then

$$\hat{f}(\xi) = a^{-n/2} e^{-\pi |\xi|^2 / a}$$

In particular if $a = 1$ so that $f(x) = e^{-\pi |x|^2}$, then

$$\hat{f} = f$$

Proof:

First consider the case $n = 1$. Since the derivative of $e^{-\pi a x^2}$ is $-2\pi a x e^{-\pi a x^2}$, by proposition 1.2.13(e) we have

$$(\hat{f})'(\xi) = (-2\pi i x e^{-\pi a x^2})^\wedge(\xi) = \frac{i}{a} (f')^\wedge(\xi) = \frac{i}{a} (2\pi i \xi) \hat{f}(\xi) = -\frac{2\pi}{a} \xi \hat{f}(\xi).$$

Then:

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{d}{d\xi} \left(e^{\pi\xi^2/a} \cdot \hat{f}(\xi) \right) &= \left[\frac{d}{d\xi} \left(e^{\pi\xi^2/a} \right) \right] \cdot \hat{f}(\xi) + e^{\pi\xi^2/a} \cdot \hat{f}'(\xi) \\
 &= e^{\frac{\pi}{a}\xi^2} \cdot \left(\frac{2\pi}{a}\xi \right) \cdot \hat{f}(\xi) + e^{\pi\xi^2/a} \cdot \hat{f}'(\xi) \\
 &= e^{\pi\xi^2/a} \left[\frac{2\pi}{a}\xi \hat{f}(\xi) + \hat{f}'(\xi) \right] \\
 &= e^{\pi\xi^2/a} \left[\frac{2\pi}{a}\xi \hat{f}(\xi) + \left(-\frac{2\pi}{a}\xi \hat{f}(\xi) \right) \right] \\
 &= e^{\pi\xi^2/a} [0] = 0
 \end{aligned}$$

It follows that $(d/d\xi)(e^{\pi\xi^2/a}\hat{f}(\xi)) = 0$, so that $e^{\pi\xi^2/a}\hat{f}(\xi)$ is constant. To evaluate the constant, set $\xi = 0$. Then computing the integral:

$$\hat{f}(0) = \int e^{-\pi ax^2} dx = a^{-1/2}.$$

The n -dimensional case follows by Fubini's theorem, since $|x|^2 = \sum_1^n x_j^2$:

$$\begin{aligned}
 \hat{f}(\xi) &= \prod_1^n \int \exp(-\pi ax_j^2 - 2\pi i\xi_j x_j) dx_j \\
 &= \prod_1^n [a^{-1/2} \exp(-\pi\xi_j^2/a)] = a^{-n/2} \exp(-\pi|\xi|^2/a).
 \end{aligned}$$

completing the proof.

Theorem 1.3.2: The Fourier Inversion Theorem

Let $f \in L^1$ and $\hat{f} \in L^1$. Then f agrees a.e. with a continuous function f_0 , and

$$(\hat{f})^\vee = (f^\vee)^\wedge = f_0$$

Proof:

Given $t > 0$ and fixed $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$, set

$$\varphi(\xi) = \exp(2\pi i\xi \cdot x - \pi t^2|\xi|^2).$$

We use the standard Gaussian $g(x) = e^{-\pi|x|^2}$ and the scaling notation $g_t(y) = t^{-n}g(y/t)$. Using the translation and dilation properties of the Fourier transform on the Gaussian, we have:

$$\hat{\varphi}(y) = t^{-n} \exp(-\pi|x - y|^2/t^2) = g_t(x - y).$$

Since $f, \varphi \in L^1$, Fubini's theorem justifies the multiplication formula $\int \hat{f}\varphi = \int f\hat{\varphi}$:

$$\int e^{-\pi t^2|\xi|^2} e^{2\pi i\xi \cdot x} \hat{f}(\xi) d\xi = \int \hat{f}(\xi) \varphi(\xi) d\xi = \int f(y) \hat{\varphi}(y) dy = f * g_t(x).$$

Now we take the limit as $t \rightarrow 0$:

1. Right hand side: since $\int g(y)dy = 1$, $\{g_t\}$ is an approximate identity. Thus $f * g_t \rightarrow f$ in the L^1 norm.
2. Left hand side: since $\hat{f} \in L^1$, the function is dominated by $|\hat{f}|$. By the Dominated Convergence Theorem, for every x :

$$\lim_{t \rightarrow 0} \int e^{-\pi t^2 |\xi|^2} e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x} \hat{f}(\xi) d\xi = \int e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x} \hat{f}(\xi) d\xi = (\hat{f})^\vee(x).$$

Since the LHS converges pointwise to $(\hat{f})^\vee$ and the RHS converges to f in L^1 (which implies pointwise convergence of a subsequence a.e.), the limits must be equal almost everywhere.

It follows that $f = (\hat{f})^\vee$ a.e. Since $(\hat{f})^\vee$ is the Fourier transform of an L^1 function $(\hat{f})$, it is continuous, completing the proof.

Corollary 1.3.3

If $f \in L^1$ and $\hat{f} = 0$, then $f = 0$ a.e.

Corollary 1.3.4: Fourier isomorphism on Schwartz Space

$\mathcal{F}$ is an isomorphism of $\mathcal{S}$ onto itself.

Proof:

By corollary 1.2.16, $\mathcal{F}$ maps $\mathcal{S}$ continuously into itself, and hence so does $f \mapsto f^\vee$, since $f^\vee(x) = \hat{f}(-x)$. By the Fourier inversion theorem, these maps are inverse to each other.

Corollary 1.3.5: Fourier Transform Has Order 4

Let $\mathcal{F}$ represent the Fourier transform. Then:

$$\mathcal{F}^4 = I$$

and 4 is the smallest such number

Proof:

First:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{F} \circ \mathcal{F}(f)(x) &= \mathcal{F}(\mathcal{F}(f)) \\ &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \hat{f}(\xi) e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x} d\xi \\ &= \int_{\mathbb{R}^d} \hat{f}(\xi) e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot (-x)} d\xi \\ &= f(-x) \end{aligned} \quad \text{Fourier inversion formula}$$

Hence applying it again gives the desired result.

We shall give a name to the representation of $f(x)$ in terms of its inversion:

Definition 1.3.6: Fourier Integral

Let $f \in L^1$ and $\hat{f} \in L^1$. Then the *Fourier integral* at x is:

$$f(x) = \int \hat{f}(\xi) e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x} d\xi$$

An important result using the Fourier inversion theorem is the dual of proposition 1.2.14:

Corollary 1.3.7: Inverse Regularity and Decay

1. **Decay $\Rightarrow$ Smoothness:** If $(1 + |\xi|)^k \hat{f}(\xi) \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ for some integer $k \geq 1$, then $f \in C^k(\mathbb{R}^n)$. The derivative is given by:

$$\partial^\alpha f(x) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (2\pi i \xi)^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi) e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x} d\xi$$

for all multi-indices $|\alpha| \leq k$.

2. **Smoothness $\Rightarrow$ Decay:** If $\hat{f} \in C^k(\mathbb{R}^n)$ and $\partial^\alpha \hat{f} \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ for all $|\alpha| \leq k$, then f decays rapidly:

$$|f(x)| \leq \frac{C}{(1 + |x|)^k}$$

for some constant C .

Proof:

The Inverse Fourier Transform is defined by:

$$f(x) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} \hat{f}(\xi) e^{2\pi i \xi \cdot x} d\xi.$$

This operator differs from the forward Fourier transform only by the sign of the exponential ($+i$ instead of $-i$). Since $|e^{i\theta}| = |e^{-i\theta}| = 1$, the absolute values used in the norm estimates and convergence arguments of ?? remain unchanged.

Thus, the proof follows immediately by applying ?? to the function $\hat{f}$ (with a trivial sign change in the derivative formula).

At last we are in a position to derive the analogue of the orthonormal basis as we have done in theorem 1.2.4:

Theorem 1.3.8: The Plancherel Theorem

If $f \in L^1 \cap L^2$, then $\hat{f} \in L^2$; and $\mathcal{F}|_{L^1 \cap L^2}$ extends uniquely to a unitary isomorphism on L^2 .

Proof:

Let $X = \{f \in L^1 : \hat{f} \in L^1\}$. Since $\hat{f} \in L^1$ implies $f \in L^\infty$, we have $X \subset L^2$ by ??, and X is dense in L^2 because $\mathcal{S} \subset X$ and $\mathcal{S}$ is dense in L^2 by proposition 1.1.12.

Given $f, g \in X$, let $h = \bar{\hat{g}}$. By the properties of the Fourier transform under complex conjugation and inversion, we have $\hat{h} = \hat{g}$. Now, using the multiplication formula (Parseval's relation for L^1):

$$\int f \bar{g} = \int f \hat{h} = \int \hat{f} h = \int \hat{f} \hat{g}.$$

Thus $\mathcal{F}|_X$ preserves the L^2 inner product. In particular, by taking $g = f$, we obtain $\|\hat{f}\|_2 = \|f\|_2$. Since $\mathcal{F}(X) = X$ by the inversion theorem, $\mathcal{F}|_X$ extends by continuity to a unitary isomorphism on L^2 .

It remains only to show that this extension agrees with $\mathcal{F}$ on all of $L^1 \cap L^2$. But if $f \in L^1 \cap L^2$ and $g(x) = e^{-\pi|x|^2}$ as in the proof of the inversion theorem, we have $f * g_t \in L^1$ by Young's inequality and $(f * g_t)^\wedge \in L^1$ because $(f * g_t)^\wedge(\xi) = e^{-\pi t^2|\xi|^2} \hat{f}(\xi)$ and $\hat{f}$ is bounded. Hence $f * g_t \in X$; moreover, by theorem 1.1.15, $f * g_t \rightarrow f$ in both the L^1 and L^2 norms. Therefore $(f * g_t)^\wedge \rightarrow \hat{f}$ both uniformly and in the L^2 norm, completing the proof.

From this, we upgrade The Hausdorff-Young Inequality over $\mathbb{R}^n$:

Theorem 1.3.9: The Hausdorff-Young Inequality

Suppose that $1 \leq p \leq 2$ and q is the conjugate exponent to p . If $f \in L^p(\mathbb{R}^n)$, then

$$\hat{f} \in L^q(\mathbb{R}^n) \quad \text{and} \quad \|\hat{f}\|_q \leq \|f\|_p$$

Folland goes on an interesting point about trying to make an $\mathbb{R}^n$ input function periodic which leads to the Poisson Summation Formula; I'm skipping this for now

(here is a theorem I want to add since it related to the analytic theorem)

Theorem 1.3.10: Fourier Decay and Analyticity

Let f be a smooth function such that its Fourier transform $\hat{f}$ satisfies the exponential decay estimate

$$|\hat{f}(\xi)| \leq C e^{-R2\pi|\xi|}$$

for some constants $C, R > 0$. Then f has a global derivative growth rate α satisfying

$$\alpha \leq \frac{1}{R}.$$

Consequently, by ??, f is analytic with radius of convergence at least R .

Proof:

Recall that the Fourier transform diagonalizes the differentiation operator. Specifically, the Fourier transform of the k -th derivative is given by $\widehat{f^{(k)}}(\xi) = (2\pi i \xi)^k \hat{f}(\xi)$. By the Fourier

inversion formula, we can express the k -th derivative as:

$$f^{(k)}(x) = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \widehat{f^{(k)}}(\xi) e^{2\pi i x \xi} d\xi = \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} (2\pi i \xi)^k \hat{f}(\xi) e^{2\pi i x \xi} d\xi.$$

We wish to bound the magnitude $M_k = \sup_x |f^{(k)}(x)|$. Applying the triangle inequality and the assumed decay bound on $\hat{f}$:

$$\begin{aligned} |f^{(k)}(x)| &\leq \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} |2\pi \xi|^k |\hat{f}(\xi)| d\xi \\ &\leq \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} (2\pi |\xi|)^k C e^{-R|\xi|} d\xi \\ &= 2C(2\pi)^k \int_0^{\infty} \xi^k e^{-R\xi} d\xi. \end{aligned}$$

The integral on the right is a standard form related to the Gamma function (specifically, $\int_0^{\infty} t^k e^{-t} dt = k!$). Making the substitution $u = R\xi$, we have $\xi = u/R$ and $d\xi = du/R$:

$$\int_0^{\infty} \xi^k e^{-R\xi} d\xi = \frac{1}{R^{k+1}} \int_0^{\infty} u^k e^{-u} du = \frac{k!}{R^{k+1}}.$$

Substituting this back into our estimate for M_k :

$$M_k \leq 2C(2\pi)^k \frac{k!}{R^{k+1}} = \left(\frac{2C}{R}\right) k! \left(\frac{2\pi}{R}\right)^k.$$

Now we compute the derivative growth rate α :

$$\begin{aligned} \alpha &= \limsup_{k \rightarrow \infty} \sqrt[k]{\frac{M_k}{k!}} \\ &\leq \limsup_{k \rightarrow \infty} \sqrt[k]{\frac{2C}{R} \left(\frac{2\pi}{R}\right)^k} \\ &= \frac{2\pi}{R}. \end{aligned}$$

(Note: The factor of 2π appears due to the chosen convention of the Fourier transform. If the decay rate R is defined relative to angular frequency, the factor vanishes). In either case, α is finite and inversely proportional to the decay constant R . Thus, the derivative growth rate is bounded, and f is analytic.

I don't know if I wanna continue this section for now, about Cesaro sums and etc

1.4 Point-wise Convergence of Fourier Series

We have established that for $f \in L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$, the Fourier series converges to f in the L^2 -norm. However, norm convergence does not imply point-wise convergence. We might ask: if we pick a specific point

x_0 , does the partial sum sequence $S_N(f)(x_0)$ converge to $f(x_0)$?

$$S_N(f)(x) = \sum_{|k| \leq N} \hat{f}(k) e^{2\pi i k \cdot x}$$

Surprisingly, for general integrable functions, the answer is often no. The mechanism governing this convergence is the *Dirichlet Kernel*.

Recall that convolution in the spatial domain corresponds to multiplication in the frequency domain. The partial sum $S_N(f)$ is the convolution of f with the inverse Fourier transform of the characteristic function of the range $[-N, N]$.

Definition 1.4.1: Dirichlet Kernel

The *Dirichlet Kernel* D_N on $\mathbb{T}^1$ is defined as:

$$D_N(x) = \sum_{k=-N}^N e^{2\pi i k x} = \frac{\sin((2N+1)\pi x)}{\sin(\pi x)}$$

Consequently, the partial sums of the Fourier series are given by:

$$S_N(f)(x) = (f * D_N)(x) = \int_{\mathbb{T}} f(x-t) D_N(t) dt$$

The equality in the above equation is a simple application of the geometric series with ratio $r = e^{2\pi i x}$:

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{k=-N}^N r^k &= r^{-N} \frac{1 - r^{2N+1}}{1 - r} = \frac{r^{-N} - r^{N+1}}{1 - r} \\ &= \frac{r^{-(N+1/2)} - r^{N+1/2}}{r^{-1/2} - r^{1/2}} \quad (\text{multiplying top and bottom by } r^{-1/2}) \\ &= \frac{e^{-2\pi i(N+1/2)x} - e^{2\pi i(N+1/2)x}}{e^{-\pi i x} - e^{\pi i x}} \\ &= \frac{-2i \sin((2N+1)\pi x)}{-2i \sin(\pi x)} = \frac{\sin((2N+1)\pi x)}{\sin(\pi x)} \end{aligned}$$

The convergence of $S_N(f)$ depends on whether D_N is a “good kernel” (an approximate identity). While $\int D_N = 1$, it fails the absolute integrability condition: $\int |D_N| \rightarrow \infty$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$. Specifically, $\|D_N\|_1 \sim \frac{4}{\pi^2} \log N$. This logarithmic growth allows for pathological behavior.

Theorem 1.4.2: Failure of Convergence

1. There exists an $f \in L^1(\mathbb{T})$ such that the Fourier series diverges *everywhere* (Kolmogorov, 1923).
2. There exists an $f \in C(\mathbb{T})$ (continuous!) such that the Fourier series diverges at a dense set of points (Du Bois-Reymond).

Proof:

We will not construct the specific function f (which requires the Uniform Boundedness Principle), but we will prove the underlying reason: the divergence of the Lebesgue constants $L_N = \|D_N\|_1$.

$$L_N = \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \left| \frac{\sin((2N+1)\pi x)}{\sin(\pi x)} \right| dx$$

Since $|\sin(\pi x)| \leq \pi|x|$, we have a lower bound:

$$L_N \geq \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \frac{|\sin((2N+1)\pi x)|}{\pi|x|} dx = 2 \int_0^{1/2} \frac{|\sin((2N+1)\pi x)|}{\pi x} dx$$

Let $u = (2N+1)\pi x$. The integral becomes:

$$\frac{2}{\pi} \int_0^{(N+1/2)\pi} \frac{|\sin u|}{u} du \geq \frac{2}{\pi} \sum_{k=1}^N \int_{(k-1)\pi}^{k\pi} \frac{|\sin u|}{u} du$$

In the interval $[(k-1)\pi, k\pi]$, $1/u \geq 1/k\pi$. Also $\int_0^\pi |\sin u| du = 2$.

$$L_N \geq \frac{2}{\pi} \sum_{k=1}^N \frac{1}{k\pi} \cdot 2 = \frac{4}{\pi^2} \sum_{k=1}^N \frac{1}{k} \sim \frac{4}{\pi^2} \log N$$

Since the norms of the operators $S_N : C(\mathbb{T}) \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ are unbounded, the Banach-Steinhaus theorem implies there exists a dense set of functions in $C(\mathbb{T})$ for which the series diverges.

This tells us that continuity alone is *not* strong enough to guarantee that we can recover the function point-wise from its frequencies using the standard summation. To guarantee convergence, we need slightly more regularity than continuity. We look for conditions that cancel out the oscillations of the Dirichlet kernel.

Theorem 1.4.3: Pointwise Convergence Tests

Let $f \in L^1(\mathbb{T})$.

1. *Dini's Criterion (Local)*: If f satisfies a local Hölder condition at x (or more generally, $\int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \left| \frac{f(x+t) - f(x)}{t} \right| dt < \infty$), then $S_N(f)(x) \rightarrow f(x)$.
2. *Dirichlet-Jordan Test (Global)*: If f is of *Bounded Variation* on $\mathbb{T}$, then for every x :

$$\lim_{N \rightarrow \infty} S_N(f)(x) = \frac{f(x^+) + f(x^-)}{2}$$

Proof:

We prove Dini's Criterion. We wish to show $S_N(f)(x) - f(x) \rightarrow 0$. Using the fact that

$\int D_N(t)dt = 1$, we write:

$$S_N(f)(x) - f(x) = \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} (f(x-t) - f(x))D_N(t)dt$$

Substitute the explicit formula for $D_N(t)$:

$$= \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} \frac{f(x-t) - f(x)}{\sin(\pi t)} \sin((2N+1)\pi t)dt$$

Define $g(t) = \frac{f(x-t)-f(x)}{t} \cdot \frac{t}{\sin(\pi t)}$. The term $\frac{t}{\sin(\pi t)}$ is bounded and smooth near $t = 0$. By the Dini condition, $\frac{f(x-t)-f(x)}{t}$ is integrable near 0. Thus $g(t) \in L^1(\mathbb{T})$. The expression becomes:

$$\int_{-1/2}^{1/2} g(t) \sin((2N+1)\pi t)dt$$

This is simply the imaginary part of the $(2N+1)$ -th Fourier coefficient of $g(t)$. By the Riemann-Lebesgue Lemma, $\hat{g}(k) \rightarrow 0$ as $k \rightarrow \infty$. Thus the integral vanishes as $N \rightarrow \infty$.

If we cannot guarantee convergence for continuous functions, we can modify our summation method. Instead of partial sums, we take the average of partial sums (Cesàro means).

Theorem 1.4.4: Fejér's Theorem

Let $\sigma_N(f) = \frac{1}{N+1} \sum_{n=0}^N S_n(f)$ be the Cesàro means. Then $\sigma_N(f) = f * K_N$, where K_N is the *Fejér Kernel*:

$$K_N(x) = \frac{1}{N+1} \left(\frac{\sin((N+1)\pi x)}{\sin(\pi x)} \right)^2$$

Unlike the Dirichlet kernel, $K_N(x) \geq 0$ and $\int K_N = 1$. Consequently, if $f \in C(\mathbb{T})$, then $\sigma_N(f) \rightarrow f$ uniformly.

Proof:

The formula for K_N follows from summing the geometric series for D_n . The key properties are: 1. $K_N(x) \geq 0$. 2. $\int_{-1/2}^{1/2} K_N(x)dx = 1$. 3. For any $\delta > 0$, $\int_{|x| \geq \delta} K_N(x)dx \rightarrow 0$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$ (Mass concentration).

Let f be continuous on $\mathbb{T}$. Since $\mathbb{T}$ is compact, f is uniformly continuous. Given $\epsilon > 0$, there exists $\delta > 0$ such that $|f(x-t) - f(x)| < \epsilon/2$ whenever $|t| < \delta$.

$$\begin{aligned} |\sigma_N(f)(x) - f(x)| &= \left| \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} (f(x-t) - f(x))K_N(t)dt \right| \\ &\leq \int_{-1/2}^{1/2} |f(x-t) - f(x)|K_N(t)dt \end{aligned}$$

Split the integral into region $A = \{|t| < \delta\}$ and $B = \{|t| \geq \delta\}$. On A : $|f(x-t) - f(x)| < \epsilon/2$. Since $\int K_N = 1$, the integral over A is $\leq \epsilon/2$. On B : $|f(x-t) - f(x)| \leq 2\|f\|_\infty$. The integral is

bounded by $2\|f\|_\infty \int_{|t|\geq\delta} K_N(t)dt$. Using the explicit formula, for $|t| \geq \delta$, $K_N(t) \leq \frac{1}{N+1} \frac{1}{\sin^2(\pi\delta)}$. As $N \rightarrow \infty$, this goes to 0. Thus for large N , the second term is $< \epsilon/2$. The convergence is uniform because δ depended only on the uniform continuity of f , not on x .

1.4.5 Historical Note For a long time, it was unknown if $f \in L^2(\mathbb{T})$ converged pointwise. In 1966, Lennart Carleson proved that if $f \in L^2(\mathbb{T})$, then $S_N(f)(x) \rightarrow f(x)$ for *almost every* x . This was later extended by Hunt to all L^p for $p > 1$. This is a deep and difficult result, requiring a careful decomposition of the operator to avoid the logarithmic divergence of L^1 .

2

Distribution Theory

Distributions a generalization of functions that allow us to give more general solutions than classical solutions, similar to how we found a weak solution last week. Locally integrable functions will be distributions (in the appropriate interpretation), but we'll see that there are general solutions that don't even fall under the notion of "function".

(A word how this is a further exploration of "dual theory")

Another use we will soon see

2.1 Intuition

For now, let $f \in L^p$. Then as we know, $(L^p)^* \cong L^q$ is an isometry where $1 \leq p < \infty$. In particular, we have that

$$g \mapsto \int fg$$

is mapped to by f . Using the Lebesgue differentiation theorem, by choosing $\varphi_k = m(B_r)^{-1} \chi_{B_r}$, where B_r is a ball of radius r around x , will allow us to recover the value of $f(x)$ for a.e. x , as $\lim_{r \rightarrow 0} \int f \varphi_r$. In this way, we can think of L^p as being embedded into $(L^q)^*$ (since we really only care what happens a.e.).

Now, let us modify the above by letting f be merely locally integrable (in L^1_{loc}), but $\varphi \in C_c^\infty$. Then it is clear that $\varphi \mapsto \int f \varphi$ is still a well-defined functional on C_c^∞ , and the pointwise values of f can be recovered a.e. from it, by extending theorem ref: HERE (8.15 in Folland, Borel Representation). Unlike in the case for L^p spaces, there are in fact *many* linear functionals on C_c^∞ that are *not* of the form $\varphi \mapsto \int f \varphi$. These, subject to some mild continuity conditions we will soon specify, will be our "generalized functions".

2.2 Definitions

We will first rapid-fire some important definitions to be up to speed with terminology. Recall that $C_c^\infty(E)$ where $E \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ is the set of all smooth functions whose support is compact and contained in E . If $U \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ is open, $C_c^\infty(U)$ is the union of space $C_c^\infty(K)$ where K ranges over all compact subsets of U . Each $C_c^\infty(K)$ is a Fréchet space with the topology defined by the norms

$$\varphi \mapsto \|\partial^\alpha \varphi\|_u \quad (\alpha \in \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}^n)$$

Thus, the sequence $\{\varphi_i\}$ converges if and only if $\partial_i^\alpha \varphi_i \rightarrow \partial^\alpha \varphi$ uniformly for all α . The completeness of $C_c^\infty(K)$ is shown through exercise 9 in the appendix in section 5.1. With these, we take the following definitions:

1. A sequence $\{\varphi_i\}$ in $C_c^\infty(U)$ converges in C_c^∞ to φ if $\{\varphi_i\} \subseteq C_c^\infty(K)$ for some compact set $K \subseteq U$ and $\varphi_i \rightarrow \varphi$ in the topology of $C_c^\infty(K)$, that is, $\partial^\alpha \varphi_i \rightarrow \partial^\alpha \varphi$ uniformly for all α
2. If X is a locally convex topological vector space and $T : C_c^\infty(U) \rightarrow X$ is a linear map, T is *continuous* if $T|_{C_c^\infty(K)}$ is continuous for each compact $K \subseteq U$, that is, if $T(\varphi_i) \rightarrow T(\varphi)$ whenever $\varphi_i \rightarrow \varphi$ in $C_c^\infty(K)$ and $K \subseteq U$ is compact (i.e. point-wise convergence)
3. A linear map $T : C_c^\infty(U) \rightarrow C_c^\infty(U')$ is *continuous* if for each compact $K \subseteq U$, there is a compact $K' \subseteq U'$ such that $T(C_c^\infty(K)) \subseteq C_c^\infty(K')$ and T is continuous from $C_c^\infty(K)$ to $C_c^\infty(K')$

With these, we will define a distribution:

Definition 2.2.1: Distribution

A *distribution* on U is a continuous linear functional on $C_c^\infty(U)$. The space of all distributions on U is denoted by $\mathcal{D}'(U)$, and we set $\mathcal{D}' = \mathcal{D}'(\mathbb{R}^n)$. We impose the weak* topology on $\mathcal{D}'(U)$, that is, the topology of pointwise convergence on $C_c^\infty(U)$.

A couple of remarks are in order: first, the $\mathcal{D}'$ notation comes from the fact that Schwartz used the notation of $\mathcal{D}$ for C_c^∞ , and so $\mathcal{D}'$ was the functionals on C_c^∞ . Next, there is a locally convex topology on C_c^∞ with respect to which sequential convergence in C_c^∞ is given by the convergence defined earlier in C_c^∞ , and the continuity of a linear map $T : C_c^\infty \rightarrow X$ and $T : C_c^\infty \rightarrow C_c^\infty$ is given by the other two points. However, to define it is relatively complicated and doesn't contribute much to the current exposition of distributions, and so will be omitted. Furthermore, when we talk about convergence of distributions $F_i \rightarrow F$, we will mean point-wise convergence.

Before giving some examples of distributions, we will remind the reader how to check for continuity in a TVS (in particular a Fréchet space)

Proposition 2.2.2: Distribution Continuity Check

Let $u : C_c^\infty(U) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ (or $\mathbb{C}$) be linear. Then $u \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$ if and only if for every compact set $K \subseteq U$, there exists a $C_K > 0$ and $N_K \in \mathbb{N}$ such that

$$\|\langle u, \varphi \rangle\| \leq C_K \sum_{\|\alpha\| \leq N_K} \|\partial^\alpha \varphi\|_{L^\infty}^\infty$$

Proof:

Given the above equation, then it is easy to check (as we've done in chapter ??) that if $\varphi_i \rightarrow \varphi$, then $\langle u, \varphi_i \rangle \rightarrow \langle u, \varphi \rangle$.

The way I like to think about the continuity check is as follows: we will soon see that there are many Distribution spaces, for example the Schwartz space $\mathcal{S}$ will have a parallel $\mathcal{S}'$. Then what the continuity condition tells us is that if $f_j \rightarrow f$ in $\mathcal{S}$ for some sequence in $\mathcal{S}$, then $f_j \rightarrow f$ in $\mathcal{S}'$ for some sequence in $\mathcal{S}'$. Hence, we can transalte convergence information from $\mathcal{S}$ to $\mathcal{S}'$.

Example 2.2.3: Distributions

1. For every $f \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(U)$, we can define a distribution on U namely the funcitonal $\varphi \mapsto \int f\varphi$, and two functions define the same distributiosn precisely when they are equal a.e.
2. Every Radon measure μ on U defines a distributiosn $\varphi \mapsto \int \varphi d\mu$.
3. If $x_0 \in U$ and α is a multi-index, the map $\varphi \mapsto \partial^\alpha(x_0)$ is a distribution that does not arise from a function; it arises from a measure μ prcisely when $\alpha = 0$, in which case μ is the point mass at x_0

As mentioned earlier, we often will associate the a function f with the distribution it has, and even label the distribution by f . For this reason, it might be confusing to write $f(\varphi)$ to mean the distribution defined by f taking in φ , and so for historical reasons we use the notation $\langle f, \varphi \rangle$.

Let's next establish some common notation:

1. First, it is often enough that we will reflect function. Thus, if we put a tilde over a function, we mean:

$$\tilde{\varphi}(x) = \varphi(-x)$$

2. Second, the point-mass is a very common distribution, which we will denote by δ :

$$\langle \delta, \varphi \rangle = \varphi(0)$$

As an example of the use of the detla funciton:

Proposition 2.2.4: Convergence To Delta Function

Let $f \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ and $\int f = a$, and for $t > 0$, let $f_t(x) = t^{-n}f(t^{-1}x)$. Then $f_t \rightarrow a\delta$ in $\mathcal{D}'$ as $t \rightarrow 0$

Proof:

If $\varphi \in C_c^\infty$, by theroem 8.15, we have:

$$\langle f_t, \varphi \rangle = \int f_t \varphi = f_t * \tilde{\varphi}(0) \rightarrow a\tilde{\varphi}(0) = a\varphi(0) = a\langle \delta, \varphi \rangle$$

completing the proof.

For equality of distributions, note that it makes to say that $F = G$ on an open set V if and only if $\langle F, \varphi \rangle = \langle G, \varphi \rangle$ for all $\varphi \in C_c^\infty(V)$. If F and G are continuous functions, this will imply they are pointwise equal, and if F and G are only locally integrable, this means they are equal a.e. on V .

Since a function in $C_c^\infty(V_1 \cup V_2)$ need not be supported in either V_1 or V_2 , it is not immediately obvious that if $F = G$ on V_1 and on V_2 then $F = G$, then $F = G$ on $V_1 \cup V_2$. However, this is the case:

Proposition 2.2.5: Equality On Support

Let $\{V_\alpha\}$ be a collection of open subsets of U and let $V = \bigcup_\alpha V_\alpha$. If $F, G \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$ and $F = G$ on each V_α , then $F = G$ on V .

Proof:

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As a consequence of proposition 2.2.5, if $F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$, there is a maximal open subset U on which $F = 0$, namely the union of all open subset on which $F = 0$. Its complement in U is called the *support* of F . If its complement is compact, it is called the *compact support*.

One of amazing facts about distributions is that even though they are not “functions”, we will be able to do many functional operations like differentiation, multiplication by a “constant”, convolution, and translation!! To achieve this, we need some theoretical build-up. Suppose U and V are open sets in $\mathbb{R}^n$ and T is a linear map from some subspace V of $L_{\text{loc}}^1(U)$ into $L_{\text{loc}}^1(V)$. Suppose that there is another linear map $T' : C_c^\infty(V) \rightarrow C_c^\infty(U)$ such that

$$\int (Tf)\varphi = \int f(T'\varphi) \quad (f \in V, \varphi \in C_c^\infty(V))$$

suppose that T' is continuous in the sense defined earlier. Then T can be extended to a map from $\mathcal{D}'(U)$ to $\mathcal{D}'(V)$, still denoted by T , by:

$$\langle TF, \varphi \rangle = \langle F, T'\varphi \rangle \quad (F \in \mathcal{D}'(U), \varphi \in C_c^\infty(V))$$

The continuity of T' guarantees that the original map T , as well as the extension to distributions, is continuous with respect to the weak* topology on distributions, namely if $F_\alpha \rightarrow F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$, then $Tf_\alpha \rightarrow TF$ in $\mathcal{D}'(V)$. With this, we can define the following on distributions

1. (Differentiation) Let $Tf = \partial^\alpha f$, defined on $C^{|\alpha|}(U)$. If $\varphi \in C_c^\infty(U)$, integration by parts gives $\int (\partial^\alpha f)\varphi = (-1)^{|\alpha|} \int f(\partial^\alpha \varphi)$; there are no boundary terms since φ has compact support. Hence $T' = (-1)^{|\alpha|} T|_{C_c^\infty(U)}$, and we can define the *derivative* $\partial^\alpha F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$ of any $F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$ by:

$$\langle \partial^\alpha F, \varphi \rangle := (-1)^{|\alpha|} \langle F, \partial^\alpha \varphi \rangle$$

By this procedure, we can define the derivatives of arbitrary locally integrable functions, even when they are not differentiable in the classical sense! We will give the derivative of certain locally integrable functions soon!!

2. (multiplication by a smooth function, a “scalar”) Let $\psi \in C^\infty(U)$ and define $Tf = \psi f$. Then evidently, $T' = T|_{C_c^\infty(U)}$, and so we can define $\psi F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$ for any $F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$ to be:

$$\langle \psi F, \varphi \rangle := \langle F, \psi \varphi \rangle$$

3. (Translation) Let $y \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and let $V = U + y = \{x + y \mid x \in U\}$. Take $T = \tau_y$ (recall that $\tau_y f(x) = f(x - y)$). Via u-substitution, we get that $\int f(x - y)\varphi(x)dx = \int f(x)\varphi(x + y)dx$, and so $T' = \tau_{-y}|_{C_c^\infty(U)}$. For a distribution $F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$, we define:

$$\langle \tau_y F, \varphi \rangle := \langle F, \tau_{-y} \varphi \rangle$$

4. (convolution with linear maps) Let S be an invertible linear transformation from $\mathbb{R}^n$ to $\mathbb{R}^n$. Letting $V = S^{-1}(U)$ and $Tf = f \circ S$, Then $T'\varphi = |\det(S)|^{-1}\varphi \circ S^{-1}$ (by change of variables, see theorem ref:HERE). Thus, for $F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$, define:

$$\langle F \circ S, \varphi \rangle := |\det S|^{-1} \langle F, \varphi \circ S^{-1} \rangle$$

5. (convolution I) Let $\psi \in C_c^\infty$, and let

$$V = \{x \mid x - y \in U \text{ for } y \in \text{supp}(\psi)\}$$

Note that V is open but may be empty. If $f \in L_{\text{loc}}^1(U)$, we get that the integral:

$$f * \psi(x) = \int f(x - y)\psi(y)dy = \int f(y)\psi(x - y)dy = \int f(\tau_x \tilde{\psi})$$

is well-defined for all $x \in V$. Since we transferred over from f to ψ , we can define for $F \in \mathcal{D}'(U)$:

$$F * \psi(x) = \langle F, \tau_x \tilde{\psi} \rangle$$

Since $\tau_x \tilde{\psi} \rightarrow \tau_{x_0} \tilde{\psi}$ as $x \rightarrow x_0$, $F * \psi$ is a continuous function (in fact, C^∞ , as we'll show in a moment). A pertinent example of this is the following:

$$\delta * \psi(x) = \langle \delta, \tau_x \tilde{\psi} \rangle = \tau_x \psi(0) = \psi(x)$$

so δ is the multiplicative identity of convolution!

6. (convolution II) Let $\psi, \tilde{\psi}$ and V be like the last point. If $f \in L_{\text{loc}}^1(U)$ and $\varphi \in C_c^\infty(U)$, then

$$\int (f * \psi)\varphi = \int \int f(y)\psi(x - y)\varphi(y)dydx = \int f(\varphi * \tilde{\psi})$$

Thus $Tf = f * \psi$ maps $L_{\text{loc}}^1(U)$ to $L_{\text{loc}}^1(V)$ and $T'\varphi = \varphi * \tilde{\psi}$. Thus, we get:

$$\langle F * \psi, \varphi \rangle = \langle F, \varphi * \tilde{\psi} \rangle$$

(theorem on how the two convolutions are actually the same thing)

Next, we will show that smooth compact functions $C_c^\infty(U)$ are dense in $\mathcal{D}'(U)$

Lemma 2.2.6: Build-Up For Density

Suppose that $\varphi \in C_c^\infty, \psi \in C_c^\infty$ and $\int \psi = 1$, and let $\psi_t(x) = t^{-n}\psi(t^{-1}x)$. Then

1. Given any neighborhood U of $\text{supp}(\varphi)$, we have $\text{supp}(\varphi * \psi_t) \subseteq U$ for t
2. $\varphi * \psi_t \rightarrow \varphi$ in C_c^∞ as $t \rightarrow 0$

Proof:

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Proposition 2.2.7: Density Of Smooth Compact Functions In DistributionsLet $U \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ be open. Then $C_c^\infty(U)$ is dense in $\mathcal{D}'(U)$ in the topology of $\mathcal{D}'(U)$ **Proof:**

Folland p. 287

2.3 Compactly Supported, Tempered, and Dense Distributions

So far, the distributions we covered need not be compactly supported (ex. $f \in L_{\text{loc}}^1$ is certainly not compactly supported). We thus take a moment to look at compactly supported distributions to take advantage of results pertaining to compactly supported functions. Let $\mathcal{E}'(U) \subseteq \mathcal{D}'(U)$ be the set of all compactly supported distributions of $\mathcal{D}'(U)$, and let $\mathcal{E}' = \mathcal{E}'(\mathbb{R}^n)$.

(Some on $\mathcal{E}'$, $\mathcal{D}'$ on with compact support)

2.4 Sobolev Spaces and Generalized Smoothness

In proposition 1.2.14, we established a correspondence between the differentiability of a function and the polynomial decay of its Fourier transform. However, classical differentiability (C^k) is a rigid concept: a function is either k -times differentiable or it is not. There is no middle ground.

In many areas of analysis (especially Partial Differential Equations and Quantum Mechanics), we need a finer scale to measure smoothness. We need to quantify functions that have “half a derivative” or are “almost continuous.” The natural setting for this is the scale of *Sobolev Spaces*.

2.4.1 Definitions and Basic Properties

Recall that $L^2(\mathbb{R}^n)$ represents functions with finite energy. By Plancherel’s Theorem, the energy is preserved in the frequency domain. If we want to measure the energy of the *derivatives*, we can use the Fourier property $\widehat{\partial^\alpha f}(\xi) \approx (2\pi i\xi)^\alpha \hat{f}(\xi)$.

Instead of requiring derivatives to exist in the classical limit sense, we simply demand that the Fourier transform is weighted sufficiently to make the “derivative energy” finite.

Definition 2.4.1: Sobolev Spaces (H^s)

For any real number $s \in \mathbb{R}$, the *Sobolev Space* $H^s(\mathbb{R}^n)$ is defined as the space of tempered distributions $f \in \mathcal{S}'(\mathbb{R}^n)$ such that:

$$\|f\|_{H^s}^2 \equiv \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (1 + |\xi|^2)^s |\hat{f}(\xi)|^2 d\xi < \infty$$

The term $(1 + |\xi|^2)^{s/2}$ is called the *Bessel potential* of order s .

Proposition 2.4.2: Properties of H^s

1. *Hilbert Space:* H^s is a Hilbert space with the inner product:

$$\langle f, g \rangle_{H^s} = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (1 + |\xi|^2)^s \hat{f}(\xi) \overline{\hat{g}(\xi)} d\xi$$

2. *Nested Scale:* If $s > t$, then $H^s(\mathbb{R}^n) \subset H^t(\mathbb{R}^n)$. Higher s implies more regularity (faster decay).
3. *Consistency with Derivatives:* For a non-negative integer k , $H^k(\mathbb{R}^n)$ coincides with the space of functions whose weak derivatives up to order k are in L^2 :

$$\|f\|_{H^k} \asymp \sum_{|\alpha| \leq k} \|\partial^\alpha f\|_{L^2}$$

The power of this definition lies in s being real. We can talk about $H^{1/2}$ (functions with "half a derivative") or even H^{-1} (distributions that are "one integration away" from being functions).

2.4.2 The Sobolev Embedding Theorem

How much L^2 -type regularity s is need to ensure my function is classically continuous? As we saw with the Step Function, merely being in L^2 ($s = 0$) or having decay $1/|\xi|$ is not enough. The following theorem gives the precise "exchange rate" between Sobolev regularity and classical C^k smoothness.

Theorem 2.4.3: Sobolev Embedding Theorem

If $s > \frac{n}{2} + k$, then:

$$H^s(\mathbb{R}^n) \subset C_0^k(\mathbb{R}^n)$$

The space of k -times continuously differentiable functions vanishing at infinity. In particular, for $n = 1$, any function with $s > 1/2$ is continuous.

Proof:

We prove the case $k = 0$ (Continuity). By the Fourier Inversion Formula, it suffices to show that $\hat{f} \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$, because the inverse transform of an L^1 function is continuous (and bounded).

Let $f \in H^s$. We use the Cauchy-Schwarz inequality to split the integrand of the L^1 norm:

$$\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} |\hat{f}(\xi)| d\xi = \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} \left(|\hat{f}(\xi)| (1 + |\xi|^2)^{s/2} \right) \left((1 + |\xi|^2)^{-s/2} \right) d\xi$$

Applying Cauchy-Schwarz ($\|uv\|_1 \leq \|u\|_2 \|v\|_2$):

$$\|\hat{f}\|_1 \leq \left(\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (1 + |\xi|^2)^s |\hat{f}(\xi)|^2 d\xi \right)^{1/2} \left(\int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (1 + |\xi|^2)^{-s} d\xi \right)^{1/2}$$

The first factor is exactly $\|f\|_{H^s}$, which is finite by assumption. The second factor is an integral of the form $\int (1 + r^2)^{-s} r^{n-1} dr$ (using polar coordinates). This integral converges at infinity if and only if the power is less than -1 :

$$-2s + n - 1 < -1 \implies -2s < -n \implies s > \frac{n}{2}.$$

Thus, if $s > n/2$, the integral converges, $\hat{f} \in L^1$, and f is continuous.

Example 2.4.4: The Step Function (The Boundary Case)

Consider the Heaviside step function $H(x)$ (multiplied by a cutoff to be in L^2). Its Fourier transform decays as $\hat{f}(\xi) \sim \frac{1}{|\xi|}$. Let us check which Sobolev space it belongs to. We need the convergence of:

$$\int_{|\xi|>1} \frac{1}{|\xi|^2} (1 + |\xi|^2)^s d\xi \approx \int_1^\infty \xi^{-2} \xi^{2s} d\xi = \int_1^\infty \xi^{2s-2} d\xi$$

This converges if $2s - 2 < -1 \implies 2s < 1 \implies s < 1/2$.

Thus, the Step Function is in H^s for all $s < 1/2$, but fails exactly at $s = 1/2$. This perfectly illustrates the embedding theorem: since it fails to reach $s > 1/2$, it is *not* forced to be continuous.

The Sobolev scale allows us to characterize “pathological” functions that are continuous but nowhere differentiable. In particular, what does a function look like if it is continuous, but lives in H^s for $s < 1/2$? It is in some ways fractal-like or has an essential discontinuity:

- *Infinite Length:* Such functions have Unbounded Variation. If you try to measure the arc length of the graph, it diverges to infinity.
- *Nowhere Differentiable:* They lack a tangent line at every single point.
- *Brownian Motion:* The path of a random particle typically belongs to $H^{1/2-\epsilon}$. It is continuous, but “roughened” by noise at all scales.

This confirms the intuition from before: decay of $1/|\xi|$ (which corresponds to $s < 1/2$) allows for “roughness” that breaks the geometry of smooth calculus.

2.4.5 Advanced: Hearing the Shape of a Fractal We previously mentioned spectral geometry for manifolds. The Sobolev dimension s allows us to define spectral geometry for *fractals*.

If a domain has a fractal boundary (like a snowflake), the decay of the Fourier transform (or the eigenvalues of the Laplacian) follows a “Weyl Law” determined by the *Hausdorff Dimension* of the boundary. The decay rate $1/|\xi|^\beta$ is directly linked to the fractal dimension D by $\beta = D - n$.

More Measures and Integrals

This last chapter will cover some additional settings in which notions of measure and integration is defined. We will examine the case of measure being defined on locally compact abelian groups and on low dimensional subsets of $\mathbb{R}^n$.

3.1 Topological Groups and Haar Measure

Definition 3.1.1: Topological Group

Let G be a group. Then G is a *topological group* if there is a topology on G such that the binary operation $(x, y) \mapsto xy$ and inversion $x \mapsto x^{-1}$ is continuous. In other words, topological groups are the group objects of **Top**.

Can you come up with an example to see why it is necessary to add this condition? Since we have a binary operation, we have a few more natural operations we may do on sets:

$$\begin{aligned} xH &= \{xh \mid h \in H\} & Ax &= \{hx \mid h \in H\} \\ H^{-1} &= \{h^{-1} \mid h \in H\} & HK &= \{hk \mid h \in H, k \in K\} \end{aligned}$$

If $A \subseteq G$ such that $A = A^{-1}$, we'll say A is *symmetric*

Example 3.1.2: Topological Group

1. For any group G , if G is equipped with the discrete topology it is a topological group, and all homomorphisms are continuous between any other topological group. In this way, the theory of topological groups can be thought as subsuming group theory. Any group with the indiscrete topology (also known as trivial topology) is also a topological group.

2. If $H \leq G$ is also a topological space, then H is a topological group with the subspace topology.
3. The real numbers $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{R}^\times$ under multiplication is a topological group (can you prove continuity of $+$, $\cdot$, and $(-)^{-1}$?). More generally, $\mathbb{R}^n$ is a topological group, or any *topological vector-space* (a vector-space where the action is continuous as well) is a topological group
4. The circle S^1 , and the n -torus $(S^1)^n$ are topological groups. show that $\mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$ is both homeomorphic and isomorphic to S^1 . If we take S^1 as a subset of $\mathbb{C}$, then we $S^1 = U(1) = \{x \in \mathbb{C} \mid |x| = 1\}$.
5. The general linear group over the reals $GL_n(\mathbb{R})$ is a topological group. Similarly, the special linear group, $SL_n(\mathbb{R}) = \{A \in GL_n \mid \det(A) = 1\}$, is a topological group.
6. Take $O(n) \subseteq GL(n)$, where $O(n) = \{A \in GL_n(\mathbb{R}) \mid AA^t = I\}$. This is a topological group known as the *orthogonal group*, since it consists of all orthonormal basis of $\mathbb{R}^n$. Similarly, we can define $U(n) = \left\{A \in GL_n(\mathbb{R}) \mid A\overline{A}^t = I\right\}$ is a topological group known as the *unitary group*. Similarly to $SL_n(\mathbb{R})$, we have:

$$SO(n) = SL_n(\mathbb{R}) \cap O(n) \quad SU(n) = SL_n(\mathbb{R}) \cap U(n)$$

Note that all these groups are *compact*.

7. (If you know some Differential Geometry) Any Lie group is naturally a topological group. An example of a topological group that is not a Lie group is $\mathbb{Q}$ with the subspace topology induced by $\mathbb{R}$.
8. The p -adic integers, $\mathbb{Z}_p$ has the induced inverse-limit topology (in this case, the p -adic topology). This group is compact, homeomorphic to the Cantor set, but is totally disconnected (hence cannot be a Lie Group)
9. Similarly to $\mathbb{Z}_p$, giving $\mathbb{Q}$ a different p -adic metric, we can take a different completion to form $\mathbb{Q}_p$, which is also a Lie Group.
10. In commutative algebra, it is common to define a topology on a group in the following way: Let G be a commutative group and take a descending sequence of subgroups^a:

$$G = G_0 \supseteq G_1 \supseteq \cdots \supseteq G_n \supseteq \cdots$$

Then let the collection of (G_n) define the *local neighborhood* of 0, and $x + G_n$ be an open neighborhood of x . Then this generate's a topology, which we'll call the *subgroup topology*. This topology is particularly important when we talk about the *completion* of groups; more on that at the end of this section.

^aIf G were not commutative, we would take a descending sequence of normal subgroups

Proposition 3.1.3: Properties Of Topological Groups

Let G be a topological group.

1. The topology of G is translation invariant: If $U \subseteq G$ is open, then Ux and xU is open
2. For every open neighborhood of e , say for example U , there is a symmetric neighborhood V of e such that $V \subseteq U$
3. For every neighborhood U of e , there is a neighborhood V of e with $VV \subseteq U$
4. if H is a subgroup of G , so is $\overline{H}$
5. Every open subgroup of G is also closed
6. If K_1, K_2 are compact subset of G , so is K_1K_2

Proof:

1. exercise (use continuity of binary operation)
- 2-3. exercise (use continuity of both operations at the identity)
4. Let $x, y \in \overline{H}$ so that there is nets $\langle x_\alpha \rangle_{\alpha \in A}$ and $\langle y_\beta \rangle_{\beta \in B}$ in H that converges to x and y . Then $x_\alpha^{-1} \rightarrow x^{-1}$ and $x_\alpha y_\beta \rightarrow xy$ (with the usual product ordering on $A \times B$), so x^{-1} and xy belong to $\overline{H}$.
5. Since H is an open subgroup, so are all xH , so $G \setminus H = \bigcup_{x \notin H} xH$ is open, hence H is closed
6. K_1K_2 is the image of the compact set $K_1 \times K_2$ under the binary operation.

Definition 3.1.4: Left And Right Translation

Let f be a continuous function on G and $y \in G$. Then a *left* translation (resp. *right* translation) of f is a function L_y (resp. R_y) that maps f to:

$$L_y f(x) = f(y^{-1}x) \quad R_y f(x) = f(xy)$$

We put y^{-1} instead of y so that translation is a homomorphism: $L_{yz} = L_y L_z$ and $R_{yz} = R_y R_z$.

Definition 3.1.5: Left And Right Uniform Continuity

Let $f : G \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ (or $\mathbb{C}$). Then f is said to be *left* (resp. *right*) *uniformly continuous* if

$$\forall \epsilon > 0, \exists V(e \in V), \|L_y f - f\| < \epsilon$$

for $y \in V$ (resp. $\|R_y f - f\|_u < \epsilon$).

Proposition 3.1.6: Compact Domain And Left/Right Uniform Continuity

Let $f \in C_c(G)$. Then f is left and right uniformly continuous.

Proof:

Folland p.340

We will mainly be working with Hausdorff groups. The following shows how this is not much of a restriction

Proposition 3.1.7: Topological Groups And Hausdorffness

Let G be a topological group. Then

1. If G is T_1 , G is Hausdorff
2. If G is not T_1 , let H be the closure of $\{e\}$. Then H is a normal subgroup and G/H (with respect to the quotient topology) is Hausdorff.

Proof:

Folland p.341

1. here
2. We first show H is normal. Evidently, H is the smallest (or minimal) closed subgroup of G (since $\{e\}$ is the smallest subgroup of G). Then H has to be normal, since if it weren't then if $H' = gHg^{-1}$ was some conjugate such that $H \neq H'$, then $H' \cap H$ would be a closed subgroup smaller than H . Hence, G/H is well-defined, and it is a simple to check that it indeed is a topological group with respect to the quotient topology. Then $\{\bar{e}\}$ is closed since its preimage of H . Finally, by continuity of the binary operation, the pre-image of a closed set is closed so the set in the preimage:

$$(\bar{x}, \bar{x}^{-1}) \mapsto \bar{e}$$

is closed in the product topology and so each $\bar{x}$ is closed making G/H Hausdorff.

^aNote that H' is closed since left and right multiplication is a homeomorphism

As a consequence of proposition 3.1.7(2), every Borel measurable function on G is constant on the cosets of H , and hence is effectively already a function on G/H , and so for the most part we may as well work with the Hausdorff group G/H . For many of the following results, we'll require the additional restraint that G be locally compact.

Definition 3.1.8: Left/Right Invariant Borel Measure

Let G be a locally compact group. Then a Borel measure μ on G is called *left-invariant* (resp. *right-invariant*) if $\mu(xE) = \mu(E)$ (resp. $\mu(Ex) = \mu(E)$) for all $x \in G$ and $E \in \mathcal{B}_G$. Similarly, a linear function I on $C_c(G)$ is called left- or right-invariant if $I(L_x(f)) = I(f)$ or $I(R_x f) = I(f)$ respectively for all f .

Definition 3.1.9: Haar Measure

Let G be a locally compact topological group. Then a *left* (resp. *right*) *Haar measure* on G is a nonzero left-invariant (resp. right-invariant) Radon measure μ on G .

Example 3.1.10: Haar Measure

1. Most famously, the Lebesgue measure is a (left- and right-invariant) Haar measure on $\mathbb{R}^n$
2. The counting measure is a (left and right) Haar measure on any group with the discrete topology
3. Let $\mathbb{T}$ be the circle group, and consider $f : [0, 2\pi] \rightarrow \mathbb{T}$ defined by

$$f(t) = (\cos(t), \sin(t))$$

then we may define the Haar measure by:

$$\mu(S) = \frac{1}{2\pi} m(f^{-1}(S))$$

where m is the Lebesgue measure on $[0, 2\pi]$. We multiplied by $(2\pi)^{-1}$ so that $\mu(T) = 1$

4. Let $G = \mathbb{R}^\times$. Then a Haar measure μ can be given by

$$\mu(S) = \int_S \frac{1}{t} dt$$

For any Borel subset $S \subseteq \mathbb{R}^\times$. For example, if $S = [a, b]$, then $\mu(S) = \log(b/a)$. This measure is indeed translation invariant since:

$$\mu(gS) = \mu([ga, gb]) = \log(gb/ga) = \log(b/a) = \mu(S)$$

and similarly for Sg . We may define a similar measure by taking

$$\mu(S) = \int_S \frac{1}{|t|} dt$$

5. Let $G = \mathrm{GL}_n(\mathbb{R})$. Then one may define a (left and right) Haar measure to be

$$\mu(S) = \int_S \frac{1}{|\det(X)|^n} dX$$

where X is the Lebesgue measure on $\mathbb{R}^{n^2}$ identified with the set of all $n \times n$ matrices (this follows from the change of variables formula).

With the Haar measure, we may naturally define Haar integrals of functions, namely

$$\int f(x) d\mu(x)$$

where μ is the Haar measure.

3.2 Pontryagin Duality

In the 19th century, Joseph Fourier was trying to find out how to model the movement of heat through solid bodies, in particular model how heat seems to dissipate and homogenise within its medium. His efforts lead to the development of *Fourier series* and the *Fourier Transform* of periodic function with sufficient regularity properties, namely that $f \in L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$ so that $\mathcal{F}(f) = \hat{f} \in \ell^2(\mathbb{Z}^n)$. Under the right conditions, we may generalize the Fourier transform to functions on $\mathbb{R}^n$ (usually, $f \in L^1(\mathbb{R}^n)$ or $f \in \mathcal{S}(\mathbb{R}^n)$). In this paper, we will extend the Fourier transform to locally compact abelian groups and show that many classical results of Fourier analysis hold.

In order to define the Fourier transformation on groups, we require the notion of *topological groups* which will allow us to define a Borel σ -algebra on which we will define a measure known as the *Haar measure*. With a measure, we may define the notion of *integrable function on a group* G . We next require the generalization of the domain of $\hat{f}$. When working with $\mathbb{T}^n$, the answer was “obvious” in that we had $\hat{f} : \mathbb{Z}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ since $\hat{f}$ enumerated the orthonormal basis of $L^2(\mathbb{T}^n)$. When we generalized the Fourier transform to functions $f \in L^p(\mathbb{R}^n)$ (for $1 \leq p \leq 2$), we had that the domain of $\hat{f}$ was $\mathbb{R}^n$, and in general the domain of $\hat{f}$ transformed like *functionals*. We will explore this concept when we define *Pontryagin Duality*.

After having introduced the relevant concepts, we shall introduce Fourier transforms on locally compact (Hausdorff) abelian group. Due to the Pontryagin duality, many classical results of Fourier Analysis are readily recovered. We shall not go over too much detail as this is more an essay than the beginning of a course in Harmonic Analysis, however some interesting highlights will be added.

The paper will end with some interesting uses and consequence of the Fourier transform and of the Pontryagin duality, including how it demonstrates compact abelian groups are just as hard to classify as abelian groups, how the Fourier Transform shows up in Representation Theory of finite groups, how Pontryagin Duality allows us to classify locally compact abelian groups through their characters.

A quick disclaimer that I will be assuming some 1st-year graduate analysis knowledge for this paper as I will have to touch on topics covered in those courses.

Let G be a locally compact (Hausdorff) abelian group. If G was also a topological vector space (i.e. a topological field k acts continuously on G so that G becomes a topological vector space), then we would have a natural notion of duality since G would be a vector space over some underlying field k . For general group, no such “natural dualizing” object exists. Instead, we may try to find some interesting group so that the contravariant functor between locally compact abelian groups (which we’ll denote **LCA**):

$$\text{Hom}(-, H) : \mathbf{LCA} \rightarrow \mathbf{LCA} \tag{3.1}$$

has properties similar to what we are used to in the dual theory we have in Functional Analysis (ex. reflexivity or properties of adjoints) and that we recover some classical results from Fourier Theory. Thanks to work by Lev Pontryagin, we have that a natural choice for H in equation (3.1) is the circle group with the usual subspace topology of $\mathbb{R}^2$. We shall henceforth label this group as $\mathbb{T}$.

Definition 3.2.1: Pontryagin Dual

Let G be a locally compact abelian group. Then

$$\widehat{G} := \text{Hom}(G, \mathbb{T})$$

where $\text{Hom}(G, \mathbb{T})$ is the collection of all continuous homomorphisms, is the *Pontryagin dual* of G endowed with the topology of uniform convergence of compact sets^a. An element of $\widehat{G}$ is called a *character* of G .

^aIf you are familiar with complex analysis, this topology is commonly used for the convergence of holomorphic functions

For a better understanding of the topology on $\widehat{G}$, consider The collection of sets

$$W_K^V := \left\{ \chi \in \widehat{G} \mid \chi(K) \subseteq V \right\}$$

where $K \subseteq G$ is a compact subset and $V \subseteq \mathbb{T}$ is a neighborhood containing the identity. Then the basis for the topology of $\widehat{G}$ is the collection of all W_K^V along with their translations. For examples of such convergence, recall power series centered at 0⁽¹⁾ on $\mathbb{C}$ with radius R converge uniformly in $B_r(0)$ when $r < R$, but it does not necessarily converge uniformly on $r = R$. Hence, power series technically converge in the *compact-open* topology².

Example 3.2.2: Pontryagin Dual

1. Let $G = \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$ with the discrete topology. Then:

$$\widehat{\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}} = \text{Hom}(\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}, \mathbb{T}) = \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$$

To see this, notice that any $f \in \widehat{G}$ is determined by where it maps 1. Since G has finite order, $f(1)$ must have finite order. Necessarily, $f(1)$ maps to a root of unity $e^{\frac{2\pi i}{k}}$ where $1 \leq k \leq n$. Now it is easy to finish the computations to see that $\widehat{\mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}} = \mathbb{Z}/n\mathbb{Z}$

2. Let $G = \mathbb{R}$. Then:

$$\widehat{\mathbb{R}} = \text{Hom}(\mathbb{R}, \mathbb{T}) = \mathbb{R}$$

To see this, we will slightly modify a proof presented in Folland's *Real Analysis* Theorem 8.19. Let $\chi \in \widehat{\mathbb{R}}$. Let $a \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $\int_0^a \chi(t) dt \neq 0$. Such an a exists, or else by the Lebesgue Differentiation Theorem $\chi = 0$ a.e. Setting $A = \left(\int_0^a \chi(t) dt\right)^{-1}$, we get:

$$\chi(x) = \chi(x)AA^{-1} = A \int_0^a \chi(x)\chi(t)dx = A \int_0^a \chi(x+t)dt = A \int_x^{x+a} \chi(t)dt$$

Since the function inside the integral continuous, χ is in fact C^1 (in fact C^∞ , but we will not need this fact). Now, notice that:

$$\chi'(x) = A[\chi(x+a) - \chi(x)] = B\chi(x)$$

¹they may be centered anywhere, but we will center them at zero for simplicity

²To be precise, they are locally uniformly convergent, which since $\mathbb{C}$ is locally compact is equivalent to uniform convergence on compact sets

where $B = A(\chi(a) - 1)$. This is now a simple ODE, which can be solved to show we get an exponential (and is unique by the uniqueness of a solution to an ODE). For an alternative approach, notice that

$$\frac{d}{dx}(e^{-Bx}\chi(x)) = 0$$

so $e^{-Bx}\chi(x)$ is constant. Since $\chi(0) = 1$, we have $\chi(x) = e^{Bx}$, and since $|\chi(x)| = 1$, B must be purely imaginary meaning $B = 2\pi i\xi$ for some $\xi \in \mathbb{R}$, completing the proof.

We may easily generalize this proof for when $G = \mathbb{R}^n$. In this case, the character's will be of the form $\chi(x) = e^{2\pi i\xi \cdot x}$ where $\xi \cdot x$ is the dot product.

3. Let $G = \mathbb{Z}$. Then:

$$\widehat{\mathbb{T}} = \text{Hom}(\mathbb{T}, \mathbb{T}) = \mathbb{Z}$$

and similarly:

$$\widehat{\mathbb{Z}} = \text{Hom}(\mathbb{Z}, \mathbb{T}) = \mathbb{T}$$

For the first, recall that $\mathbb{T} \cong \mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}$. Then looking at the above proof, we would consider χ to be periodic with period 1 and $e^{2\pi i\xi} = 1$ if and only if $\xi \in \mathbb{Z}$. A similar argument works for the second case.

Looking at this from a second perspective, from usual Fourier Analysis we know that the Fourier transform is a map $\mathcal{F} : L^2(\mathbb{T}) \rightarrow \ell^2(\mathbb{Z})$, and so it should be expected that $\mathbb{Z}$ and $\mathbb{T}$ are Pontryagin dual to each other.

You may ask if it is always the case that that $\widehat{\widehat{G}} = G$ just like for vector-spaces. We know that in general duality theory, this is not the case (the dual of the dual may be much larger than the original object, think of $C_b(X)$). If it is the case, that means that the dual $\widehat{G}$ of G contains all the required information about G . For Pontryagin duality, it is always reflexive:

Theorem 3.2.3: Pontryagin Duality Theorem

Let G be a locally compact abelian group. Then there is a natural isomorphism:

$$G \mapsto \widehat{\widehat{G}}$$

mapping $g \mapsto \text{ev}_g$ where $\text{ev}_g : \widehat{G} \rightarrow G$ is defined by $\text{ev}_g(\chi) = \chi(g)$.

We shall delay the proof until we have the notion of Fourier Transform for groups, and due to its complexity only present some interesting parts of it. Note that in general, $G \not\cong \widehat{\widehat{G}}$ (think of $L^p(X) \not\cong L^q(X) = (L^p(X))^*$), however if G is finite and abelian then $G \cong \widehat{\widehat{G}}$ (though not canonically). The essential take away from Pontryagin duality is that $\widehat{G}$ contains enough information on G to recover G .

3.2.4 Remark The map in theorem 3.2.3 can in fact be augmented to be a covariant functor (even an exact functor, i.e. it preserves short exact sequences). Hence, we may look at the study of extending group or the homology of groups in the Pontryagin dual.

The statement that the Fourier transform changes the basis from “positions” $\{\delta_x\}$ to “waves” $\{e^{ikx}\}$

hints at a broader duality: it changes the very nature of the “points” that constitute our space.

Let us define a function f by its values at geometric points. In the language of distributions, we can write any function as a continuous sum of Dirac deltas:

$$f(x) = \int_{\mathbb{T}^1} f(y) \delta_y(x) dy$$

Here, the building blocks are points $y \in \mathbb{T}^1$. A “point” is simply a linear functional that evaluates a function at a specific location: $\text{ev}_y(f) = f(y)$.

Now consider the Fourier Transform. It maps a function f on the group G to a function $\hat{f}$ on the dual group $\hat{G}$ (the set of characters). What are the “points” of this new space? They are the irreducible representations (the frequencies).

$$\hat{f}(\chi) = \int_G f(x) \overline{\chi(x)} dx$$

When we transform a geometric point δ_y , it becomes a function on the dual group:

$$\hat{\delta}_y(\chi) = \overline{\chi(y)}$$

This reveals that the Fourier Transform is an isomorphism between two different kinds of spaces:

- The *Physical Space* G , whose points are geometric locations x .
- The *Spectral Space* $\hat{G}$, whose points are irreducible representations χ .

This is a specific instance of a grander theme in mathematics known as *Gelfand Duality*. In this framework, any commutative C^* -algebra (like the algebra of continuous functions) corresponds to a topological space (its spectrum). The Fourier Transform is the map that identifies the algebra of functions under convolution ($L^1(G)$) with the algebra of functions under pointwise multiplication ($C_0(\hat{G})$). Effectively, we trade the geometry of the group for the geometry of its representation theory.

3.2.1 Generalizing the Fourier Transform

We may now combine all we have defined into the following

Definition 3.2.5: L^1 Fourier Transform On Group

Let $f \in L^1(G)$. Then define the *Fourier Transform* of f to be $\hat{f} : \hat{G} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ via

$$\hat{f}(\chi) = \int_G f(x) \overline{\chi(x)} d\mu(x)$$

This definition is the proper generalization of Fourier transform. Let’s say $G = \mathbb{R}$ with the usual Lebesgue measure. Then as we saw in example 3.2.2, χ is the map $\xi \mapsto e^{-2\pi i \xi}$ so that

$$\hat{f}(\chi) = \int_{\mathbb{R}} f(x) e^{2\pi i \xi} dx$$

3.2.6 Remark The Fourier transform $f \mapsto \hat{f}$ is the *Gelfand Transformation* of f . If we take $A(\hat{G}) = \{\hat{f} \mid f \in L^1(G)\}$, then $A(\hat{G})$ is a separating sub-algebra of $C_0(\hat{G})$. It is also not too hard to see that it is self-adjoint, and so by the Stone-Weierstrass theorem it is dense in $C_0(\hat{G})$.

By our usual Fourier theory, we recover some important properties, namely:

Proposition 3.2.7: Properties Of Abstract Fourier Transform

Let $f \in L^1(G)$ where G is a locally compact (Hausdorff) abelian group with a Haar measure μ . Then:

1. $\mathcal{F}(f * g) = \mathcal{F}(f)\mathcal{F}(g)$
2. $\widehat{L_x f(\chi)} = \hat{f}(\chi)$
3. The Riemann-Lebesgue lemma holds

Proof:

1. This is from direct computation and applying Fubini's Theorem and properties of the character:

$$\begin{aligned} \widehat{(f * g)}(\xi) &= \int \int f(x - y)g(y)\overline{\chi(x)}dydx \\ &= \int \int f(x - y)\overline{\chi(x - y)}g(y)\overline{\chi(y)}dx dy \\ &= \hat{f}(\xi) \int g(y)\overline{\chi(y)}dy \\ &= \hat{f}(\xi)\hat{g}(\xi) \end{aligned}$$

2. Usually, $\mathcal{F}(L_y f)(x) = e^{-2\pi i y x} f(x)$. For the Fourier transform on groups, we get that its translation invariant since

$$\widehat{L_x f(\chi)} = \int_G f(x^{-1}y)\overline{\chi(y)}dy = \int_G f(y)\overline{\chi(y)}dy = \hat{f}(\chi)$$

3. (Riemann-Lebesgue Lemma) Notice that the map $\mathcal{F}$ mapping f to $\hat{f}$ maps $L^1(G)$ to bounded continuous functions. Since the integral is finite and the image of the characters is $\mathbb{T}$ (namely we may bound it with $\sup_{x \in G} |\chi(x)|$), $\hat{f}$ will vanish at infinity. In fact, $\mathcal{F}$ is norm decreasing and hence is continuous. Hence, we may write

$$\mathcal{F} : L^1(G) \rightarrow BC_0(G)$$

where $BC_0(G)$ is the collection of bounded continuous functions that vanish at infinity.

One of the most important results in Fourier Analysis is the ability to recover f from $\hat{f}$ under suitable

conditions, that is the *Fourier Inversion Theorem*. This result naturally generalizes. Note that since $f \in L^1(G)$, we may treat f as being defined μ -a.e., and so we may only recover f μ -a.e. in the following theorem unless f has more regularity:

Theorem 3.2.8: Fourier Inversion Theorem For Groups

Let G be a locally compact abelian group with Haar measure μ . Then there is a unique Haar measure $\hat{\mu}$ on $\hat{G}$ such that whenever $f \in L^1(G)$ and $\hat{f} \in L^1(\hat{G})$, then μ -a.e. we have:

$$f(x) = \int_{\hat{G}} \hat{f}(\chi) \chi(x) d\hat{\mu}(\chi)$$

If f is continuous, then this is true for all $x \in G$

Proof:

See:

D. Ramakrishnan and R. J. Valenza, *Fourier analysis on number fields* (Graduate Texts in Mathematics, vol. 186, Springer, 1999), chapter 3.

Another very important result is Fourier Analysis on L^2 ;

Theorem 3.2.9: Plancherel Inversion Theorem For Groups

Let G be a locally compact abelian group, μ a Haar measure on G , and $\hat{\mu}$ the dual measure on $\hat{G}$ given in theorem 3.2.8. If $f : G \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ is continuous with compact support, then $\hat{f} \in L^2(\hat{G})$ and

$$\int_G |f(x)|^2 d\mu(x) = \int_{\hat{G}} |\hat{f}(\chi)|^2 d\hat{\mu}(\chi)$$

In particular, The Fourier transform is an L^2_μ isometry from $C_c(G)$ to $L^2_\mu(\hat{G})$

Proof:

See *Fourier Analysis on Groups* by Walter Rudin, Chapter 3.

The Plancherel formula allows us to generalize the space on which the Fourier transform is defined. To see this, first note that $C_c(G)$ and $L^2(G)$ are Banach spaces. By a classical result in Real analysis, $C_c(G)$ is L^2 -dense in $L^2(G)$. By proposition 2.1.11 in *Analysis Now*, there is a unique extension from $C_c(G)$ to $L^2(G)$ of the Fourier transform so that we get a *unitary operator*

$$\mathcal{F} : L^2_\mu(G) \rightarrow L^2_\mu(\hat{G})$$

If G is compact, then $L^2(G) \subseteq L^1(G)$, and hence we get this result for general L^2 -functions. If G is *not* locally compact, then to define the L^2 Fourier transform, we would start on some dense subspace like $C_c(G)$ and then extend isometrically to the whole space using Plancherel's Theorem.

Finally, we can recover the inverse Fourier transform of the dual group for the L^2 Fourier transform

Theorem 3.2.10: Dual Group Fourier Transform

Let G be a locally compact abelian group with Haar measure μ and let $\mathcal{F}$ be the L^2 Fourier transform. Then the adjoint of the Fourier Transform restricted to continuous functions on compact support is the Inverse Fourier Transform

$$L^2_\mu(\widehat{G}) \rightarrow L^2_\mu(G)$$

Proof:

See *Fourier Analysis on Groups* by Walter Rudin, Chapter 3.

Notable example would be when $G = \mathbb{T}$ so that $\widehat{G} = \mathbb{Z}$ and the Fourier transform computes the Fourier series of periodic functions. If G is finite, then we will get the *discrete Fourier Transform* from this process.

3.2.2 Proof Pontryagin Dual

We come back now to Pontryagin duality and prove a special case of it:

Proof:

(of Pontryagin Duality)

This theorem is rather difficult to prove. We shall prove that α is injective, where $\alpha : G \rightarrow \widehat{\widehat{G}}$ is defined by $g \mapsto \text{ev}_g$ (the evaluation map at g). The proof can be completed by showing that α is in fact a dense embedding onto its image, which since α is over a locally compact Hausdorff spaces will make α an open map, and hence must map to the entire codomain, completing the proof.

Let $f \in L^1(G)$ and $\chi \in \widehat{G}$. Recall that $\widehat{L_x f} = \widehat{f}$, and so by the Fourier inversion theorem, $L_x f = f$ for all $f \in C_c^+(G)$ (the set of all continuous positive operators with compact support). Let $x \in G \setminus \{e\}$. Suppose for the sake of contradiction that $\alpha(x) = 1$, that is $\chi(x) = 1$ for all $\chi \in \widehat{G}$. We shall show that this contradicts $L_x f = f$. Since G is Hausdorff, there exists an open neighborhood U of e such that

$$U \cap (x^{-1}U) = \emptyset$$

Without loss of generality we may choose U so that it lies in a compact neighborhood of the identity. Then by Urysohn's lemma, there exists a continuous positive definition function $f \neq 0$ with support in U . Since $f \in L^1(G)$ and f is compactly supported and positive, $f \in C_c^+(G)$. Then the support of f and $L_x f$ are disjoint, but that contradicts $L_x f = f$, completing the proof.

For more information, see <https://www.math.uh.edu/~haynes/files/topgps8.pdf>

3.2.3 Interesting Uses

Pontryagin has a couple of very interesting consequences, perhaps a good starting point is that the classification of compact abelian groups is just as difficult as the classification of general abelian groups using the following result:

Theorem 3.2.11: Compactness Criterion For LCA Group

Let G be a locally compact abelian group. Then G is compact if and only if $\widehat{G}$ is discrete. Conversely, G is discrete if and only if $\widehat{G}$ is compact.

Proof:

The fact that G is compact implies $\widehat{G}$ is discrete and that G is discrete implies $\widehat{G}$ is compact comes straight from the topology of G and $\widehat{G}$ (namely that it is the compact-open topology). To get the converse of both, we simply apply Pontryagin duality.

Proposition 3.2.12: Unit In $L^1(G)$

Let G be a locally compact abelian group with Haar measure μ . Then $L^1(G)$ has a unit if and only if G is discrete.

Proof:

We know that $L^1(G)$ always has an approximate identity (think of good kernels). The identity of $L^1(G)$ would be an element such that $f * \text{id} = \text{id} * f = f$, so $\widehat{f} \cdot \widehat{\text{id}} = \widehat{f}$. We see through this formula that $\widehat{\text{id}}$ would have to be the Dirac-delta distribution at 1 with norm 1. This distribution is a function if and only if G is discrete.

Representation Theory

Another place this comes in is within representation theory. Recall in [NateAlgebra] there was a quick word on Fourier transforms in representation theory. In classical representation theory of finite groups, we define the character to be $\chi : G \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^*$. Since G is finite, G maps to a root of unity in $\mathbb{T}$, and hence the notion of character in classical representation theory aligns with our definitions. Then we may define the inner product of characters to be:

$$\langle \chi_1, \chi_2 \rangle = \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{g \in G} \chi_1(g) \overline{\chi_2(g)}$$

which will give a way to decompose representations into irreducible components via irreducible characters. If G is abelian, then may translate the decomposition theorem for representations of finite abelian groups to the decomposition of $L^2(G)$ via

$$L^2(G) = \bigoplus_{i=1}^n E_n$$

and in the infinite case we would have take the closure

$$L^2(G) = \widehat{\bigoplus_{i \in \mathbb{N}} E_n}$$

where E_n are the subspaces given by the usual orthonormal basis for L^2 when doing Fourier analysis. Hence, representation theory and Fourier analysis are linked!!

Class Field Theory

For those who have seen some class field theory, they have seen the Artin Reciprocity map. Recall that the idele group is a locally compact group, and so it is precisely the context in which we expect Pontryagin duality to be applied! In the local case, we have the Artin map $K^* \cong \text{Gal}_K(K^{\text{ab}})$ between two locally compact groups; taking the Pontryagin dual will preserve this mapping and let us work with the characters of these groups! In the global case using the Adèle ring and Idele group, we shall not get an isomorphism in the Pontryagin dual but a perfect pairing.

Part II

Appendix, Index, Bibliography

A

Decay vs. Smooth Table for Fourier

This table represents the relationship between the smoothness of a function and the decay of its Fourier transform:

Function Space	Symbol	Property of $f(x)$	Property of $\hat{f}(\xi)$ (Dual)
The "Nice" Spaces (High Regularity)			
Real Analytic	$C^\omega(\mathbb{R})$	Holomorphic Extension: Analytic in a strip	Exponential Decay: $ \hat{f}(\xi) \leq Ce^{-a \xi }$ ($\Longleftrightarrow$)
Compact Smooth	$C_c^\infty(\mathbb{R})$	Extreme Locality: Zero outside a box	Extreme Regularity: Entire Analytic Function
Schwartz	$\mathcal{S}(\mathbb{R})$	Rapid Decay: Faster than polynomial	Rapid Decay: Faster than polynomial ($\Longleftrightarrow$)
Finite Smoothness	$C^k(\mathbb{R})$	Finite Regularity: k derivatives exist	Polynomial Decay: Decays like $1/ \xi ^k$
The "Rough" Spaces (Low Regularity)			
Wiener Algebra	$A(\mathbb{R})$	Continuous + Integrable: f is bounded, continuous	Absolute Convergence: $\hat{f} \in L^1$ ($\implies f \in C^0$)
Square Integrable	$L^2(\mathbb{R})$	Finite Energy: Isometry	Finite Energy: Isometry ($\Longleftrightarrow$ Plancherel)
Integrable	$L^1(\mathbb{R})$	Finite Area: (Riemann-Lebesgue)	Slow Decay: Continuous, $\rightarrow 0$ ($\not\implies L^1$)
Distributions (Compact Support)	$\mathcal{E}'(\mathbb{R})$	Singular: Dirac Deltas, etc.	Polynomial Growth: $ \hat{f}(\xi) \leq C(1 + \xi)^N$ ($\Longleftrightarrow$)

Table A.1: The Duality of Regularity and Decay in Real Analysis

This next table illustrates the “Hierarchy of Continuous Regularity”. It answers the question: How jagged is the function, and how much high-frequency energy is required to describe that jaggedness? As you move down the table, the function becomes “rougher” (more singular), and consequently, its Fourier Transform $\hat{f}(\xi)$ decays slower.

Function Class	Property	Example $f(x)$	Decay of $\hat{f}(\xi)$
High Regularity (Fast Decay)			
Real Analytic (C^ω)	Holomorphic Strip (Super-Smooth)	$e^{-\pi x^2}$ (Gaussian)	Exponential $O(e^{-a \xi })$
Smooth (C_c^∞)	infinitely diff.	$e^{-1/(1-x^2)}$ (Bump Func)	Rapid Decay $O(\xi ^{-N})$ for all N
Finite Smoothness (C^k)	k derivatives (Continuous $f^{(k)}$)	$x^k x $ (Splines)	Polynomial $o(\xi ^{-k})$
Medium Regularity (Algebraic Decay)			
Lipschitz ($C^{0,1}$)	Bounded Derivative (Finite Slope)	$ x $ (Triangle Wave)	Linear $O(\xi ^{-1})$
Hölder ($C^{0,\alpha}$)	Infinite Derivative (Vertical Cusp)	$ x ^\alpha$ ($0 < \alpha < 1$)	Fractional $O(\xi ^{-\alpha})$
Bounded Variation (BV)	Finite Total Variation (Step / Monotonic)	$\text{sign}(x)$ (Square Wave)	Linear $O(\xi ^{-1})$
Low Regularity (Slow Decay)			
Wiener Algebra ($A(\mathbb{T})$)	Abs. Conv. Fourier (Always Continuous)	$\sum \frac{\sin(nx)}{n^2}$ (Weierstrass)	Summable $\hat{f} \in \ell^1$
Continuous (C^0)	**Not** BV (Wild Oscillations)	$x \sin(1/x)$ (Damped Osc.)	Arbitrarily Slow $o(1)$ (Riemann-Lebesgue)
Integrable (L^1)	Finite Area	–	Arbitrarily Slow $o(1)$ (Riemann-Lebesgue)
Distributions ($\mathcal{D}'$)	Singular (Not a function)	$\delta(x)$ (Impulse)	Growth $O(\xi ^N)$

Table A.2: The Precise Spectrum of Continuity and Fourier Decay (Corrected)

In this hierarchy, the decay rate $1/|\xi|^s$ tells us exactly how “smooth” the function is.

1. Integer Powers ($s = k$): These correspond to existence of Weak Derivatives. A function has a weak derivative if its slope is well-behaved enough to have finite energy (L^2), even if it has kinks or jumps. For example, the absolute value function $|x|$ has no classical derivative at 0, but its "weak derivative" is the Step Function (which is perfectly valid in physics as a force field).
2. Fractional Powers ($s = k.5$): These correspond to the Geometry of the Singularity. They tell us whether a sharp point is a “needle” (Cusp), a “corner” (Lipschitz), or a “smooth turn” (Curvature). The higher the power s , the more "damped" the high frequencies are, and the harder it is for the function to make sudden changes.

Decay Rate	Smoothness Class	Allowed Singularity	Physical Intuition
$1/ \xi $	L^2 (Finite Energy) Discontinuous	Jump (Step Function)	Teleportation Position breaks instantly.
$1/ \xi ^{1.5}$	C^0 (Continuous) Infinite Slope	Cusp (Vertical Tangent)	Lightning Rod Sharpest possible point.
$1/ \xi ^2$	$C^{0,1}$ (Lipschitz) Finite Slope	Corner (Kink)	Brick Wall Velocity breaks instantly.
$1/ \xi ^{2.5}$	C^1 (Smooth) Continuous Slope	Curvature Singularity (Infinite Curvature)	Tight Turn Acceleration explodes.
$1/ \xi ^3$	$C^{1,1}$ (Bounded Curvature) Continuous Velocity	Acceleration Jump (Finite Curvature Jump)	Kick Force turns on instantly.

Table A.3: The Fine Structure of Fourier Decay and Singularities

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